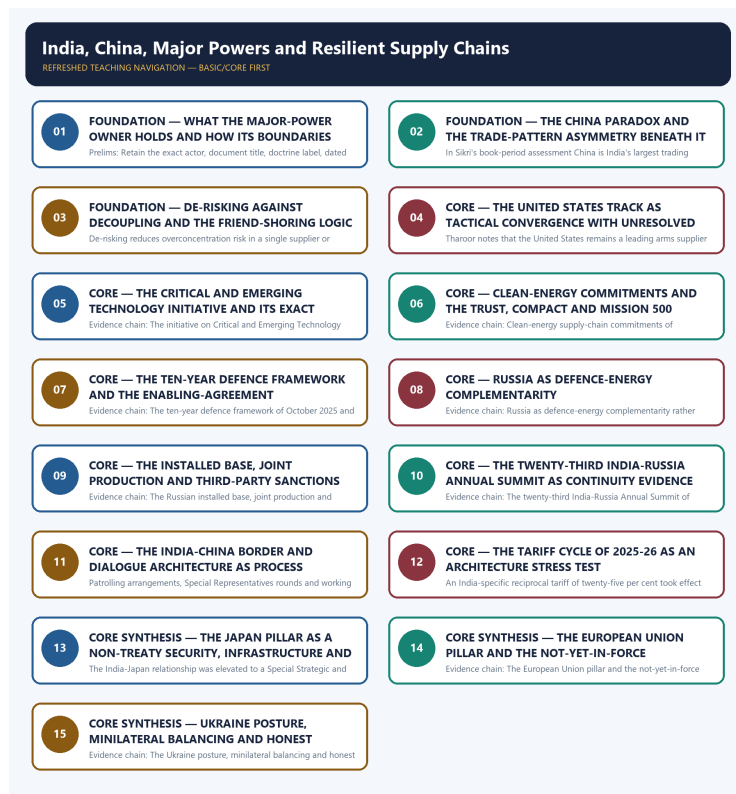


COMPLETE LEARNING SESSION

India, China, Major Powers and Resilient Supply Chains - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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India, China, Major Powers and Resilient Supply Chains - Learner-v2 Complete Learning Session

Authoring-only generation: 2026-09-03. No PDF was rendered and no tracker or index was mutated.

SOURCE, PROGRESSION AND CURRENT-LINKAGE AUDIT

- **Generation date:** 2026-09-03.
- **Repository-first evidence:** the Basic owner is taught first and preserved in full; the Advanced owner is retained only in the optional final teaching block.
- **OCR evidence:** Repository Markdown was primary. The OCR-searchable official General Studies question papers held under books\mains and books\more_previous_papers were read only to confirm the printed wording of routed demands. No official answer key, marking scheme, page precision or unsupported quotation was imported from them.
- **Qdrant:** not used; repository Markdown and available OCR context were sufficient.
- **PYQ integrity:** Four General Studies Paper II Mains demands are routed to this topic in the audited routing ledgers and each is reproduced below as a demand card with its printed year, paper, question number, directive, marks and word limit exactly as the ledger records them: 2019 General Studies Paper II question 9 on the India-Japan contemporary global and strategic partnership, a Comment demand of 10 marks and 150 words; 2019 General Studies Paper II question 20 on friction in India-United States ties and India's place in United States global strategy, an Explain with suitable examples demand of 15 marks and 250 words; 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 on the United States facing an existential challenge from China, an Explain demand of 10 marks and 150 words; and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9 on the West fostering India as an alternative to China's supply chain, an Explain demand of 10 marks and 150 words. For the three 2019 and 2021 demands the ledger records that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership and that the word limits are taken from the instruction block. Two objective demands are also routed to this owner and are carried as coverage requirements only: 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan, for which the official key is not held locally, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which only a provisional 2026 Set-A key is present locally. No option or answer letter is recorded or inferred for either objective demand, and the provisional status of the 2026 key is preserved exactly. The supplied paper text of the 2024 demand carries apparent grammatical and spelling defects, and the owners require that it be reproduced as printed rather than silently corrected, which is done in the corresponding demand card below. The locally held OCR-searchable official General Studies papers were read only to confirm the printed wording of the routed Mains demands; no question was invented from them, no stem was paraphrased into an apparent routing, and no marking scheme or page precision was imported. Every model solution below is original work written to the repository's examiner-grade standard using the claim, named evidence, analysis and qualification pattern, and none of them reproduces or claims an official answer.
- **Live-link boundary:** Live official verification was attempted on 2026-09-03 against the Ministry of External Affairs press-release, bilateral-document and country-brief pages and against the Press Information Bureau release index. Each attempt is recorded honestly above: the Ministry pages returned a browser-requirement stub or the Ministry's own error page and the Press Information Bureau index returned HTTP 403, so no new live item was obtained. The package therefore uses only the dated official anchors already carried by the repository owners, each with its actor, exact evidentiary level and date. It invents no treaty or joint-statement wording, no border or diplomatic status, no summit outcome, no trade, tariff, investment or supply-chain figure, no initiative membership or participation category, no military or security development, no declared policy position, no previous-year question, no answer key and no current claim.
- **Fact/inference discipline:** no current-affairs item, PYQ wording, figure or quotation is invented.

LIVE OFFICIAL-SOURCE ATTEMPT LOG

Every live check below was attempted on 2026-09-03 in the priority order required for International Relations: Ministry of External Affairs official pages first, then other official government or international-organisation documents. Access failures are recorded exactly as observed and no claim is reconstructed from a failed fetch.

- <https://www.mea.gov.in/press-releases.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to a browser-requirement stub and returned no press release text, so no live item was taken from it.
- <https://www.mea.gov.in/bilateral-documents.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to a browser-requirement stub and returned no bilateral document text, so no live item was taken from it.
- <https://www.mea.gov.in/foreign-relation.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to the Ministry's own error page, so no country brief was taken from it.
- <https://www.pib.gov.in/indexd.aspx?reg=3&lang=1> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request returned HTTP 403, so no release was taken from it.

BASIC LEARNING SESSION

DEEP-REVIEW LEARNING CONTRACT

Control	Binding rule for this package
Syllabus boundary	Complete International Relations Basic/Core is answer-complete before optional Advanced depth.
Status boundary	Announced, negotiated, initialled, signed, ratified, entered into force, operational, suspended and completed remain distinct.
Institutional method	Treaty basis or political character -> exact membership/status -> mandate -> decision rule -> national instrument -> implementation -> outcome.
Level mapping	Bilateral, subregional/regional, minilateral/plurilateral and systemic levels are separated and then connected.
Policy method	Strategic objective -> chosen instrument -> implementing actors/resources -> observed output/outcome -> alternative and residual risk.
Evidence method	Claim -> named India-centric treaty, institution, corridor, operation, agreement or summit -> analysis -> official source/date/status and causal qualification.
Neutrality method	Contested borders, maritime claims and conflicts are attributed neutrally; policy doctrine is distinguished from retrospective analytical label.
Practice contract	Every solved item has demand decoding, a detailed examiner-grade model, executable timed/compression plan, marks rationale and answer-specific improvement.
Approval	This immutable successor remains approved: false pending explicit approval.

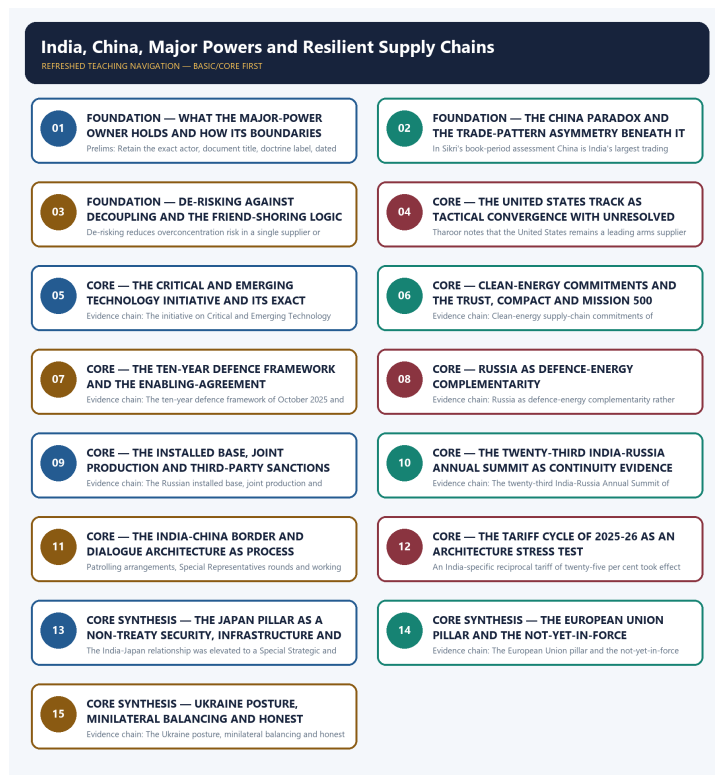
Canonical Basic/Core owner: upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\International-Relations\basic\03_India-China-Major-Powers-and-Resilient-Supply-Chains.md **Substantive canonical provenance owner:** upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\International-Relations\03_India-China-Major-Powers-and-Resilient-Supply-Chains_Learner-V2-Complete-Topic-Package.md **Optional Advanced owner:** upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\International-Relations\advanced\03_India-China-Major-Powers-and-Resilient-Supply-Chains.md **Official syllabus mapping:** upsc-ai-kit\knowledge\International-Relations\OFFICIAL-UPSC-SYLLABUS-MAPPING.md

EVIDENCE, PYQ AND CURRENT-STATUS CONTROL

- **Membership discipline:** member, observer, dialogue partner, chair, guest and invited participant are not interchangeable; verify the relevant date.
- **Mandate discipline:** treaty organisation, UN organ, specialised agency, court, summit process, political forum, coalition and unilateral retain exact legal character and competence.
- **Agreement discipline:** announcement, negotiation, signature, ratification, entry into force, domestic implementation and measured outcome remain separate.
- **Connectivity discipline:** concept, financing, contract, construction, trial movement, operational segment, completed corridor and commercially viable use remain separate.
- **Conflict discipline:** distinguish verified event, party claim, independent attribution, legal characterisation and analytical inference; use neutral language for contested borders and conflicts.
- **Causal discipline:** chronology, summit language, trade change, deployment or project completion does not alone establish strategic effect; state mechanism, counterfactual and alternatives.
- **Trade-off discipline:** interests, capabilities, constraints, partner agency, escalation, dependence, finance, legitimacy, domestic distribution, alternatives and implementation risks are explicit.
- **PYQ discipline:** exact wording is preserved only where verified; routed or reconstructed demands remain labelled and no model is presented as an official UPSC answer.
- **Current-status note, rechecked 2026-09-03:** volatile relations, agreements, corridors, operations, conflicts, trade and summit outcomes retain official source, publication date and operative/interim/completed status; stale officeholders are omitted.

Generation-local live/current sources:

- <https://www.mea.gov.in/press-releases.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to a browser-requirement stub and returned no press release text, so no live item was taken from it.
- <https://www.mea.gov.in/bilateral-documents.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to a browser-requirement stub and returned no bilateral document text, so no live item was taken from it.
- <https://www.mea.gov.in/foreign-relation.htm> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request redirected to the Ministry's own error page, so no country brief was taken from it.
- <https://www.pib.gov.in/indexd.aspx?reg=3&lang=1> - attempted 2026-09-03; the request returned HTTP 403, so no release was taken from it.



Refreshed teaching navigation

Distinct embedded teaching-navigation image. The separate continuous Cārvāka-style flowchart package remains an independent at-a-glance artifact.

SESSION 1 - FOUNDATION - WHAT THE MAJOR-POWER OWNER HOLDS AND HOW ITS BOUNDARIES ARE ROUTED

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: What this owner holds and how its boundaries are routed Qualified use: Open a major-power demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

Technical definition: Prelims: Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to What the major-power owner holds and how its boundaries are routed, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: What this owner holds and how its boundaries are routed Qualified use: Open a major-power demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- FOUNDATION
- What the major-power owner holds
- how its boundaries are routed
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- This

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define What the major-power owner holds, connect how its boundaries are routed with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

WHAT THE MAJOR-POWER OWNER HOLDS AND HOW ITS BOUNDARIES ARE ROUTED

01. What this owner holds and how its boundaries are routed

BOUNDARY -> Trade mechanics belong to Economy, grouping profiles to topic 10, systemic de-risking to topic 11 and Security Council reform to topic 12.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Trade mechanics belong to Economy, grouping profiles to topic 10, systemic de-risking to topic 11 and Security Council reform to topic 12.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to What the major-power owner holds and how its boundaries are routed, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Open a major-power demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** What this owner holds and how its boundaries are routed
- **Qualified use:** Open a major-power demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - WHAT THE MAJOR-POWER OWNER HOLDS AND HOW ITS BOUNDARIES ARE ROUTED

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - What the major-power owner holds and how its boundaries are routed

|
v

EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION · What the major-power owner holds · how its boundaries are routed ·
Evidence chain · Qualified use · This

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Prelims: Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to What the major-power owner holds and how its boundaries are routed, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Mains: Open a major-power demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: this topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union...

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: What this owner holds and how its boundaries are routed
Qualified use: Open a major-power demand by fixing ownership so the answer does not drift into another owner's evidence.

SESSION 2 - FOUNDATION - THE CHINA PARADOX AND THE TRADE-PATTERN ASYMMETRY BENEATH IT

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: The India-China economic-strategic paradox - Trade-pattern asymmetry as an economic grievance layered on strategic mistrust
Qualified use: Separate economic interdependence from strategic trust, which is the commonest scoring error on this topic.

Technical definition: In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The India-China economic-strategic paradox - Trade-pattern asymmetry as an economic grievance layered on strategic mistrust
Qualified use: Separate economic interdependence from strategic trust, which is the commonest scoring error on this topic.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- FOUNDATION
- The China paradox
- the trade-pattern asymmetry beneath it
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- In Sikri's book-period assessment China

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define The China paradox, connect the trade-pattern asymmetry beneath it with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE CHINA PARADOX AND THE TRADE-PATTERN ASYMMETRY BENEATH IT

01. The India-China economic-strategic paradox

|
v

02. Trade-pattern asymmetry as an economic grievance layered on strategic mistrust

BOUNDARY -> Book-period ranking and the over ten billion dollar deficit are period evidence, not current figures.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement.
- Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Book-period ranking and the over ten billion dollar deficit are period evidence, not current figures.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The China paradox and the trade-pattern asymmetry beneath it, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Separate economic interdependence from strategic trust, which is the commonest scoring error on this topic.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The India-China economic-strategic paradox -> Trade-pattern asymmetry as an economic grievance layered on strategic mistrust
- **Qualified use:** Separate economic interdependence from strategic trust, which is the commonest scoring error on this topic.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - THE CHINA PARADOX AND THE TRADE-PATTERN ASYMMETRY BENEATH IT

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - The China paradox and the trade-pattern asymmetry beneath it

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v

EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION • The China paradox • the trade-pattern asymmetry beneath it • Evidence chain • Qualified use • In Sikri's book-period assessment China

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement.

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v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track.

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v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Book-period ranking and the over ten billion dollar deficit are period evidence, not current figures.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The India-China economic-strategic paradox - Trade-pattern asymmetry as an economic grievance layered on strategic mistrust Qualified use: Separate economic interdependence from strategic trust, which is the commonest scoring error on this topic.

SESSION 3 - FOUNDATION - DE-RISKING AGAINST DECOUPLING AND THE FRIEND-SHORING LOGIC

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: De-risking against decoupling - Friend-shoring and trusted supply chains as the Western policy logic Qualified use: Use the correct policy term so the answer describes India's actual posture rather than a stronger one.

Technical definition: De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: De-risking against decoupling - Friend-shoring and trusted supply chains as the Western policy logic Qualified use: Use the correct policy term so the answer describes India's actual posture rather than a stronger one.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- FOUNDATION
- De-risking against decoupling
- the friend-shoring logic
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use

- De-risking

How to use them: Frame the answer through FOUNDATION; define De-risking against decoupling, connect the friend-shoring logic with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

DE-RISKING AGAINST DECOUPLING AND THE FRIEND-SHORING LOGIC

01. De-risking against decoupling

|
v

02. Friend-shoring and trusted supply chains as the Western policy logic

BOUNDARY -> Diversification is not replacement, and full substitution away from China-linked inputs is a multi-year undertaking.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner.
- Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Diversification is not replacement, and full substitution away from China-linked inputs is a multi-year undertaking.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to De-risking against decoupling and the friend-shoring logic, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Use the correct policy term so the answer describes India's actual posture rather than a stronger one.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** De-risking against decoupling -> Friend-shoring and trusted supply chains as the Western policy logic
- **Qualified use:** Use the correct policy term so the answer describes India's actual posture rather than a stronger one.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - FOUNDATION - DE-RISKING AGAINST DECOUPLING AND THE FRIEND-SHORING LOGIC

START / CONCEPT: FOUNDATION - De-risking against decoupling and the friend-shoring logic
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v
EXACT TERMS: FOUNDATION • De-risking against decoupling • the friend-shoring logic • Evidence chain
• Qualified use • De-risking
|
v
MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner.
|
v
CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Diversification is not replacement, and full substitution away from China-linked inputs is a multi-year undertaking.
|
v
UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale.
|
v
ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: De-risking against decoupling - Friend-shoring and trusted supply chains as the Western policy logic Qualified use: Use the correct policy term so the answer describes India's actual posture rather than a stronger one.

SESSION 4 - CORE - THE UNITED STATES TRACK AS TACTICAL CONVERGENCE WITH UNRESOLVED FRICTION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier.

Technical definition: Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The United States track as technology-led tactical convergence - Technology-access asymmetry as unresolved friction
Qualified use: Adopt the vocabulary discipline that keeps the relationship correctly classified throughout the answer.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Tharoor
- United States
- India
- Sikri

How to use them: Frame the answer through Evidence chain; define Qualified use, connect Tharoor with United States to explain the mechanism, and use India for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE UNITED STATES TRACK AS TACTICAL CONVERGENCE WITH UNRESOLVED FRICTION

01. The United States track as technology-led tactical convergence

|
v

02. Technology-access asymmetry as unresolved friction

BOUNDARY -> Continuing restrictions on high-technology sales remain unresolved, so convergence is not unconditional access.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India.
- Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Continuing restrictions on high-technology sales remain unresolved, so convergence is not unconditional access.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The United States track as tactical convergence with unresolved friction, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Adopt the vocabulary discipline that keeps the relationship correctly classified throughout the answer.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The United States track as technology-led tactical convergence -> Technology-access asymmetry as unresolved friction
- **Qualified use:** Adopt the vocabulary discipline that keeps the relationship correctly classified throughout the answer.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE UNITED STATES TRACK AS TACTICAL CONVERGENCE WITH UNRESOLVED FRICTION

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The United States track as tactical convergence with unresolved friction

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v

EXACT TERMS: Evidence chain • Qualified use • Tharoor • United States • India • Sikri

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Continuing restrictions on high-technology sales remain unresolved, so convergence is not unconditional access.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The United States track as technology-led tactical convergence - Technology-access asymmetry as unresolved friction Qualified use: Adopt the vocabulary discipline that keeps the relationship correctly classified throughout the answer.

SESSION 5 - CORE - THE CRITICAL AND EMERGING TECHNOLOGY INITIATIVE AND ITS EXACT STATUS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: CORE - The critical and emerging technology initiative and its exact status comprises The critical, emerging technology initiative and its exact status as its core connected dimensions.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology and its exact status
Qualified use: Cite the dated technology instrument that a supply-chain demand expects, without inflating its legal character.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology and its exact status
Qualified use: Cite the dated technology instrument that a supply-chain demand expects, without inflating its legal character.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The critical
- emerging technology initiative
- its exact status
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Critical

How to use them: Frame the answer through The critical; define emerging technology initiative, connect its exact status with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE CRITICAL AND EMERGING TECHNOLOGY INITIATIVE AND ITS EXACT STATUS

01. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology and its exact status

BOUNDARY -> It is a cooperation initiative, not a treaty or framework agreement, and not a defence alliance.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- It is a cooperation initiative, not a treaty or framework agreement, and not a defence alliance.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The critical and emerging technology initiative and its exact status, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Cite the dated technology instrument that a supply-chain demand expects, without inflating its legal character.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology and its exact status
- **Qualified use:** Cite the dated technology instrument that a supply-chain demand expects, without inflating its legal character.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE CRITICAL AND EMERGING TECHNOLOGY INITIATIVE AND ITS EXACT STATUS

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The critical and emerging technology initiative and its exact status

|
v

EXACT TERMS: The critical · emerging technology initiative · its exact status · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Critical

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: It is a cooperation initiative, not a treaty or framework agreement, and not a defence alliance.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology and its exact status Qualified use.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology and its exact status Qualified use: Cite the dated technology instrument that a supply-chain demand expects, without inflating its legal character.

SESSION 6 - CORE - CLEAN-ENERGY COMMITMENTS AND THE TRUST, COMPACT AND MISSION 500 BRANDING

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Clean-energy supply-chain commitments of September 2024 - TRUST, COMPACT and Mission 500 of February 2025 Qualified use: Add two further dated examples of Western diversification interest without asserting a legal succession.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: Clean-energy supply-chain commitments of September 2024 - TRUST, COMPACT and Mission 500 of February 2025 Qualified use: Add two further dated examples of Western diversification interest without asserting a legal succession.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Clean-energy commitments
- the TRUST
- COMPACT
- Mission 500 branding
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use

How to use them: Frame the answer through Clean-energy commitments; define the TRUST, connect COMPACT with Mission 500 branding to explain the mechanism, and use Evidence chain for the decisive comparison or

qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

CLEAN-ENERGY COMMITMENTS AND THE TRUST, COMPACT AND MISSION 500 BRANDING

01. Clean-energy supply-chain commitments of September 2024

|
v

02. TRUST, COMPACT and Mission 500 of February 2025

BOUNDARY -> The official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded the earlier initiative.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available.
- Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- The official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded the earlier initiative.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Clean-energy commitments and the TRUST, COMPACT and Mission 500 branding, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Add two further dated examples of Western diversification interest without asserting a legal succession.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Clean-energy supply-chain commitments of September 2024 -> TRUST, COMPACT and Mission 500 of February 2025
- **Qualified use:** Add two further dated examples of Western diversification interest without asserting a legal succession.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - CLEAN-ENERGY COMMITMENTS AND THE TRUST, COMPACT AND MISSION 500 BRANDING

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Clean-energy commitments and the TRUST, COMPACT and Mission 500 branding

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v

EXACT TERMS: Clean-energy commitments · the TRUST · COMPACT · Mission 500 branding · Evidence chain
· Qualified use

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession.

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v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded the earlier initiative.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: Clean-energy supply-chain commitments of September 2024 - TRUST, COMPACT and Mission 500 of February 2025 Qualified use: Add two further dated examples of Western diversification interest without asserting a legal succession.

SESSION 7 - CORE - THE TEN-YEAR DEFENCE FRAMEWORK AND THE ENABLING-AGREEMENT ARCHITECTURE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The ten-year defence framework of October 2025 and its non-treaty character - The enabling-agreement architecture and what it does not create Qualified use: Evidence defence depth precisely while refusing alliance language that would misstate India's obligations.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The ten-year defence framework of October 2025 and its non-treaty character - The enabling-agreement architecture and what it does not create Qualified use: Evidence defence depth precisely while refusing alliance language that would misstate India's obligations.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The ten-year defence framework
- the enabling-agreement architecture
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- United States-India Major Defense Partnership

- Kuala Lumpur

How to use them: Frame the answer through The ten-year defence framework; define the enabling-agreement architecture, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use United States-India Major Defense Partnership for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE TEN-YEAR DEFENCE FRAMEWORK AND THE ENABLING-AGREEMENT ARCHITECTURE

01. The ten-year defence framework of October 2025 and its non-treaty character

|

v

02. The enabling-agreement architecture and what it does not create

BOUNDARY -> A framework and three enabling agreements create interoperability, not collective defence or basing rights.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment.
- The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A framework and three enabling agreements create interoperability, not collective defence or basing rights.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The ten-year defence framework and the enabling-agreement architecture, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Evidence defence depth precisely while refusing alliance language that would misstate India's obligations.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The ten-year defence framework of October 2025 and its non-treaty character -> The enabling-agreement architecture and what it does not create

- **Qualified use:** Evidence defence depth precisely while refusing alliance language that would misstate India's obligations.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE TEN-YEAR DEFENCE FRAMEWORK AND THE ENABLING-AGREEMENT ARCHITECTURE

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The ten-year defence framework and the enabling-agreement architecture

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v

EXACT TERMS: The ten-year defence framework · the enabling-agreement architecture · Evidence chain · Qualified use · United States-India Major Defense Partnership · Kuala Lumpur

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v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defense Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment.

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v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: A framework and three enabling agreements create interoperability, not collective defence or basing rights.

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v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Mains: Evidence defence depth precisely while refusing alliance language that would misstate India's obligations.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The ten-year defence framework of October 2025 and its non-treaty character - The enabling-agreement architecture and what it does not create Qualified use: Evidence defence depth precisely while refusing alliance language that would misstate India's obligations.

SESSION 8 - CORE - RUSSIA AS DEFENCE-ENERGY COMPLEMENTARITY

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Complementarity describes the whole relationship while the narrower spares dependence must be named separately.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: Russia as defence-energy complementarity rather than one-sided dependence
Qualified use: Use the accurate relational term and then isolate the specific dependence that carries risk.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- **Russia as defence-energy complementarity**
- **Evidence chain**
- **Qualified use**
- **Sikri**
- **India-Russia**
- **India**

How to use them: Frame the answer through Russia as defence-energy complementarity; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with Sikri to explain the mechanism, and use India-Russia for the decisive comparison or

qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

RUSSIA AS DEFENCE-ENERGY COMPLEMENTARITY

01. Russia as defence-energy complementarity rather than one-sided dependence

BOUNDARY -> Complementarity describes the whole relationship while the narrower spares dependence must be named separately.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Complementarity describes the whole relationship while the narrower spares dependence must be named separately.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Russia as defence-energy complementarity, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Use the accurate relational term and then isolate the specific dependence that carries risk.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** Russia as defence-energy complementarity rather than one-sided dependence
- **Qualified use:** Use the accurate relational term and then isolate the specific dependence that carries risk.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - RUSSIA AS DEFENCE-ENERGY COMPLEMENTARITY

START / CONCEPT: CORE - Russia as defence-energy complementarity

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v

EXACT TERMS: Russia as defence-energy complementarity · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Sikri · India-Russia · India

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v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Evidence chain: Russia as defence-energy complementarity rather than one-sided dependence Qualified use: Use the accurate relational term and then isolate the specific dependence that carries risk.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Complementarity describes the whole relationship while the narrower spares dependence must be named separately.

|

v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: use the accurate relational term and then isolate the specific dependence that carries risk.

|

v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks.

SESSION 9 - CORE - THE INSTALLED BASE, JOINT PRODUCTION AND THIRD-PARTY SANCTIONS EXPOSURE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The Russian installed base, joint production and third-party sanctions exposure Qualified use: Convert a dependence claim into a bounded, evidenced argument instead of a general assertion.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The Russian installed base, joint production and third-party sanctions exposure Qualified use: Convert a dependence claim into a bounded, evidenced argument instead of a general assertion.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The installed base
- joint production
- third-party sanctions exposure
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Licensed

How to use them: Frame the answer through The installed base; define joint production, connect third-party sanctions exposure with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE INSTALLED BASE, JOINT PRODUCTION AND THIRD-PARTY SANCTIONS EXPOSURE

01. The Russian installed base, joint production and third-party sanctions exposure

BOUNDARY -> Delivery status and crude volumes are unverified without an official figure, and exposure is not a legal duty.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Delivery status and crude volumes are unverified without an official figure, and exposure is not a legal duty.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The installed base, joint production and third-party sanctions exposure, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Convert a dependence claim into a bounded, evidenced argument instead of a general assertion.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The Russian installed base, joint production and third-party sanctions exposure
- **Qualified use:** Convert a dependence claim into a bounded, evidenced argument instead of a general assertion.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE INSTALLED BASE, JOINT PRODUCTION AND THIRD-PARTY SANCTIONS EXPOSURE

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The installed base, joint production and third-party sanctions exposure

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v

EXACT TERMS: The installed base · joint production · third-party sanctions exposure · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Licensed

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Delivery status and crude volumes are unverified without an official figure, and exposure is not a legal duty.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the Russian installed base, joint production and third-party sanctions exposure Qualified use.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The Russian installed base, joint production and third-party sanctions exposure Qualified use: Convert a dependence claim into a bounded, evidenced argument instead of a general assertion.

SESSION 10 - CORE - THE TWENTY-THIRD INDIA-RUSSIA ANNUAL SUMMIT AS CONTINUITY EVIDENCE

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit of December 2025 Qualified use: Cite one dated continuity anchor to prove that the Russia track was not sacrificed.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit of December 2025 Qualified use: Cite one dated continuity anchor to prove that the Russia track was not sacrificed.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit as continuity evidence
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- India-Russia Annual Summit
- New Delhi
- President Putin's

How to use them: Frame the answer through The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit as continuity evidence; define Evidence chain, connect Qualified use with India-Russia Annual Summit to explain the mechanism, and use New Delhi for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE TWENTY-THIRD INDIA-RUSSIA ANNUAL SUMMIT AS CONTINUITY EVIDENCE

01. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit of December 2025

BOUNDARY -> The summit evidences continuity and adopted documents; it evidences no delivery or volume number.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- The summit evidences continuity and adopted documents; it evidences no delivery or volume number.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit as continuity evidence, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Cite one dated continuity anchor to prove that the Russia track was not sacrificed.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit of December 2025
- **Qualified use:** Cite one dated continuity anchor to prove that the Russia track was not sacrificed.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE TWENTY-THIRD INDIA-RUSSIA ANNUAL SUMMIT AS CONTINUITY EVIDENCE

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit as continuity evidence

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v

EXACT TERMS: The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit as continuity evidence · Evidence chain · Qualified use · India-Russia Annual Summit · New Delhi · President Putin's

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Mains: Cite one dated continuity anchor to prove that the Russia track was not sacrificed.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit of December 2025 Qualified use.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit of December 2025 Qualified use: Cite one dated continuity anchor to prove that the Russia track was not sacrificed.

SESSION 11 - CORE - THE INDIA-CHINA BORDER AND DIALOGUE ARCHITECTURE AS PROCESS

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: The India-China border and dialogue architecture as process, not settlement Qualified use: Refuse the settlement reading while still crediting the dated de-escalation and dialogue steps.

Technical definition: Patrolling arrangements, Special Representatives rounds and working mechanisms are process, not settlement.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The India-China border and dialogue architecture as process, not settlement Qualified use: Refuse the settlement reading while still crediting the dated de-escalation and dialogue steps.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- The India-China border
- dialogue architecture as process
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- Patrolling
- Special Representatives

How to use them: Frame the answer through The India-China border; define dialogue architecture as process, connect Evidence chain with Qualified use to explain the mechanism, and use Patrolling for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE INDIA-CHINA BORDER AND DIALOGUE ARCHITECTURE AS PROCESS

01. The India-China border and dialogue architecture as process, not settlement

BOUNDARY -> Patrolling arrangements, Special Representatives rounds and working mechanisms are process, not settlement.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Patrolling arrangements, Special Representatives rounds and working mechanisms are process, not settlement.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The India-China border and dialogue architecture as process, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Refuse the settlement reading while still crediting the dated de-escalation and dialogue steps.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The India-China border and dialogue architecture as process, not settlement
- **Qualified use:** Refuse the settlement reading while still crediting the dated de-escalation and dialogue steps.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE INDIA-CHINA BORDER AND DIALOGUE ARCHITECTURE AS PROCESS

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The India-China border and dialogue architecture as process

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v

EXACT TERMS: The India-China border · dialogue architecture as process · Evidence chain · Qualified use · Patrolling · Special Representatives

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Patrolling arrangements, Special Representatives rounds and working mechanisms are process, not settlement.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: The resulting consequence is that the India-China border and dialogue architecture as process, not settlement Qualified use.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the India-China border and dialogue architecture as process, not settlement Qualified use.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The India-China border and dialogue architecture as process, not settlement Qualified use: Refuse the settlement reading while still crediting the dated de-escalation and dialogue steps.

SESSION 12 - CORE - THE TARIFF CYCLE OF 2025-26 AS AN ARCHITECTURE STRESS TEST

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: The United States tariff cycle of 2025-26 as an architecture stress test
Qualified use: Supply the decisive counter-evidence to a one-directional fostering reading of Western interest.

Technical definition: An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The United States tariff cycle of 2025-26 as an architecture stress test
Qualified use: Supply the decisive counter-evidence to a one-directional fostering reading of Western interest.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- Evidence chain
- Qualified use
- An India-specific
- Executive Order
- Russian-oil-linked
- 2025-26

How to use them: Frame the answer through Evidence chain; define Qualified use, connect An India-specific with Executive Order to explain the mechanism, and use Russian-oil-linked for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE TARIFF CYCLE OF 2025-26 AS AN ARCHITECTURE STRESS TEST

01. The United States tariff cycle of 2025-26 as an architecture stress test

BOUNDARY -> Every measure was executive-order-based, dated and reversible, so no standing rate may be quoted.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Every measure was executive-order-based, dated and reversible, so no standing rate may be quoted.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The tariff cycle of 2025-26 as an architecture stress test, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Supply the decisive counter-evidence to a one-directional fostering reading of Western interest.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The United States tariff cycle of 2025-26 as an architecture stress test
- **Qualified use:** Supply the decisive counter-evidence to a one-directional fostering reading of Western interest.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE - THE TARIFF CYCLE OF 2025-26 AS AN ARCHITECTURE STRESS TEST

START / CONCEPT: CORE - The tariff cycle of 2025-26 as an architecture stress test

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v

EXACT TERMS: Evidence chain · Qualified use · An India-specific · Executive Order · Russian-oil-linked · 2025-26

|

v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy.

|

v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Every measure was executive-order-based, dated and reversible, so no standing rate may be quoted.

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v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the United States tariff cycle of 2025-26 as an architecture stress test Qualified use.

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v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The United States tariff cycle of 2025-26 as an architecture stress test Qualified use: Supply the decisive counter-evidence to a one-directional fostering reading of Western interest.

SESSION 13 - CORE SYNTHESIS - THE JAPAN PILLAR AS A NON-TREATY SECURITY, INFRASTRUCTURE AND TECHNOLOGY PARTNER

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Evidence chain: The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security, infrastructure and technology partner Qualified use: Widen the diversification argument beyond the United States without overstating any single instrument.

Technical definition: The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security, infrastructure and technology partner Qualified use: Widen the diversification argument beyond the United States without overstating any single instrument.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- CORE SYNTHESIS
- The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security

- infrastructure
- technology partner
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security, connect infrastructure with technology partner to explain the mechanism, and use Evidence chain for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE JAPAN PILLAR AS A NON-TREATY SECURITY, INFRASTRUCTURE AND TECHNOLOGY PARTNER

01. The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security, infrastructure and technology partner

BOUNDARY -> Logistics access is not collective defence and a matching mechanism is not relocated production.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Logistics access is not collective defence and a matching mechanism is not relocated production.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security, infrastructure and technology partner, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Widen the diversification argument beyond the United States without overstating any single instrument.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security, infrastructure and technology partner
- **Qualified use:** Widen the diversification argument beyond the United States without overstating any single instrument.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - THE JAPAN PILLAR AS A NON-TREATY SECURITY, INFRASTRUCTURE AND TECHNOLOGY PARTNER

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security, infrastructure and technology partner

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v

EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS · The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security · infrastructure · technology partner · Evidence chain · Qualified use

↓
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production.

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v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Logistics access is not collective defence and a matching mechanism is not relocated production.

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v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the Japan pillar as a non-treaty security, infrastructure and technology partner Qualified use.

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v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security, infrastructure and technology partner Qualified use: Widen the diversification argument beyond the United States without overstating any single instrument.

SESSION 14 - CORE SYNTHESIS - THE EUROPEAN UNION PILLAR AND THE NOT-YET-IN-FORCE QUALIFICATION

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The European Union pillar and the not-yet-in-force qualification Qualified use: Apply the legal-status discipline in its clearest form inside a live economic-diplomacy example.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The European Union pillar and the not-yet-in-force qualification Qualified use: Apply the legal-status discipline in its clearest form inside a live economic-diplomacy example.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- CORE SYNTHESIS
- The European Union pillar
- the not-yet-in-force qualification
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use

- The European Union-India Trade

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define The European Union pillar, connect the not-yet-in-force qualification with Evidence chain to explain the mechanism, and use Qualified use for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

THE EUROPEAN UNION PILLAR AND THE NOT-YET-IN-FORCE QUALIFICATION

01. The European Union pillar and the not-yet-in-force qualification

BOUNDARY -> A concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- A concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to The European Union pillar and the not-yet-in-force qualification, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Apply the legal-status discipline in its clearest form inside a live economic-diplomacy example.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The European Union pillar and the not-yet-in-force qualification
- **Qualified use:** Apply the legal-status discipline in its clearest form inside a live economic-diplomacy example.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - THE EUROPEAN UNION PILLAR AND THE NOT-YET-IN-FORCE QUALIFICATION

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - The European Union pillar and the not-yet-in-force qualification

|
v

EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS · The European Union pillar · the not-yet-in-force qualification ·
Evidence chain · Qualified use · The European Union-India Trade

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: A concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Do not miss this limiting distinction: the European Union pillar and the not-yet-in-force qualification Qualified use.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The European Union pillar and the not-yet-in-force qualification Qualified use: Apply the legal-status discipline in its clearest form inside a live economic-diplomacy example.

SESSION 15 - CORE SYNTHESIS - UKRAINE POSTURE, MINILATERAL BALANCING AND HONEST QUESTION OWNERSHIP

DEFINITION / WHAT THIS IS CALLED

Plain-language definition: Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

Technical definition: Evidence chain: The Ukraine posture, minilateral balancing and honest question ownership
Qualified use: Close with the systemic frame, the coordination limit and an explicit ownership boundary.

ANSWER-GRABBING OPENING - WRITE/ADAPT IN THE EXAM

Evidence chain: The Ukraine posture, minilateral balancing and honest question ownership
Qualified use: Close with the systemic frame, the coordination limit and an explicit ownership boundary.

MUST-WRITE KEYWORDS

- CORE SYNTHESIS
- Ukraine posture
- minilateral balancing

- honest question ownership
- Evidence chain
- Qualified use

How to use them: Frame the answer through CORE SYNTHESIS; define Ukraine posture, connect minilateral balancing with honest question ownership to explain the mechanism, and use Evidence chain for the decisive comparison or qualification.

VISUAL FIRST

UKRAINE POSTURE, MINILATERAL BALANCING AND HONEST QUESTION OWNERSHIP

01. The Ukraine posture, minilateral balancing and honest question ownership

BOUNDARY -> Minilateral coordination costs are real, and no routed demand may be force-fitted or answered from a key.

This topic-specific rail fixes the evidence sequence and its exam boundary before analysis.

CORE EXPLANATION

Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

NAMED EVIDENCE AND MECHANISM

- Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

EXAMINER CAUTION

- Minilateral coordination costs are real, and no routed demand may be force-fitted or answered from a key.

EXAM LINK

- **Prelims:** Retain the exact actor, document title, doctrine label, dated instrument and evidentiary level attached to Ukraine posture, minilateral balancing and honest question ownership, and never upgrade a vision statement into a treaty, a signature into a ratification, a participation category into membership, or an announced corridor into an operating one.
- **Mains:** Close with the systemic frame, the coordination limit and an explicit ownership boundary.

MINI RECAP

- **Evidence chain:** The Ukraine posture, minilateral balancing and honest question ownership
- **Qualified use:** Close with the systemic frame, the coordination limit and an explicit ownership boundary.

COMPLETE BASIC OWNER EVIDENCE BANK

Subject: International Relations | **Tier:** Must-Do (foundation) | **GS Paper:** GS-II. **Core area:** India's relationships with the US, China, Russia, the EU and Japan; supply-chain resilience and critical/emerging technologies.
Grounded in: Rajiv Sikri, *Challenges and Strategy: Rethinking India's Foreign Policy*; Shashi Tharoor, *Pax Indica*; MEA/White House iCET documentation; 00_Master-Framework.md Sections 2 and 4. **FACT:** = source-grounded | **ANALYSIS:** = analytical inference | **CURRENT:** = current anchor. *Companion:* advanced/03_India-China-Major-Powers-and-Resilient-Supply-Chains.md.

1. Visual foundation

MAJOR-POWER RELATIONSHIPS

US (technology, defence trade, strategic convergence)	CHINA (largest trade partner, deep mistrust, unresolved boundary)	RUSSIA (defence, energy, continuity partnership)
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SUPPLY-CHAIN RESILIENCE AGENDA
friend-shoring, trusted supply chains,
critical minerals, semiconductors

STRATEGIC-AUTONOMY FILTER
(topic 01: engage every power on its
own interest merits, not as a bloc choice)

OUTCOME: DIVERSIFIED, HEDGED
TECHNOLOGY AND SUPPLY PARTNERSHIPS

Core proposition: ANALYSIS: India manages three structurally different major-power relationships simultaneously - deep economic interdependence with strategic mistrust (China), a rapidly deepening technology/defence partnership (the US), and continuity-based defence-energy complementarity (Russia) - and channels all three into a supply-chain resilience and strategic-autonomy agenda rather than choosing a single patron.

2. Essential definitions

Concept	Exam-ready meaning
FACT: India-China economic-strategic paradox	FACT: In Sikri's book-period assessment, "China is today India's largest trading partner... although the economic relationship is not without its problems," while at the same time "India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion." Use current official trade data for any present-day ranking claim.
ANALYSIS: Friend-shoring / trusted supply chains	Relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone - the policy logic behind India-US and India-EU technology cooperation.
FACT: iCET (initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology)	An India-US cooperation initiative announced in May 2022, with its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second NSA-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, AI, defence-industrial cooperation and space - a cooperation initiative, not a treaty or framework agreement.
CURRENT: TRUST and COMPACT (13 February 2025)	Two India-US initiatives announced in the same joint leaders' statement: TRUST ("Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology") for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT ("Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce & Technology"). ANALYSIS: The official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET - treat it as a successor/parallel branding, not a documented replacement.
FACT: India-Russia defence-energy complementarity	FACT: Sikri: "India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one," and Russia remains, per Sikri, "the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure hi-tech equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines."
ANALYSIS: De-risking vs. decoupling	De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier/partner while retaining engagement; decoupling implies a full disengagement - India's posture is consistently de-risking, not decoupling, from China.
ANALYSIS: Critical minerals and semiconductors	Inputs (rare earths, lithium, cobalt; chip fabrication and packaging capacity) treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities under the resilience agenda - Economy owns the trade/production mechanics.

3. How the major-power/supply-chain mechanism works

- China: interdependence with mistrust.** FACT: In Sikri's book-period assessment, China is India's largest trading partner, yet "India's relationship with China is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute" - trade volume does not translate into strategic trust.
- US: technology-led convergence.** FACT: Tharoor notes the US remains "a leading arms supplier to India," and Sikri observes that "after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness, India and the US are" moving toward closer alignment - though FACT: Tharoor also flags continuing "restrictions on the sale of US high technology to India" as unresolved friction.
- Russia: continuity through defence-energy ties.** FACT: Sikri: Russia's defence relationship gives India access to equipment "unavailable from elsewhere," while energy complementarity (India energy-deficient, Russia energy-surplus) sustains the partnership independent of Western alignment shifts.
- Supply-chain resilience response:** the West's interest in reducing

overconcentration on China channels into India-specific instruments (iCET, semiconductor cooperation, clean-energy supply-chain commitments).

5. **Strategic-autonomy filter applied:** each relationship is pursued on its own

interest logic (topic 01) - deepening US technology ties does not require ending Russian defence/energy ties or abandoning China trade engagement.

4. Institutions and agreements

- FACT: **iCET** (announced May 2022; inaugural NSA-level meeting 31 January 2023;

second NSA-level review 17 June 2024):** the two National Security Advisers reviewed India-US critical-and-emerging-technology cooperation, including semiconductors, AI, space and defence-industrial cooperation.

- CURRENT: **India-US clean-energy supply-chain commitments, 21 September 2024:**

bilateral commitments on clean-energy supply-chain resilience, announced alongside the broader technology partnership.

- CURRENT: **TRUST and COMPACT (13 February 2025):** the current India-US technology and defence-commerce initiative branding, announced together with **Mission 500** (a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade) and the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement.

- CURRENT: **Framework for the US-India Major Defense Partnership** (signed Kuala Lumpur, 31 October 2025):** a ten-year defence framework. ANALYSIS: A framework, not a mutual-defence treaty; India has no collective-defence obligation to the US.

- CURRENT: **US tariff cycle affecting India (2025-26):** an India-specific reciprocal tariff of 25% took effect 7 August 2025 (Executive Order 14326) and an additional 25% Russian-oil-linked duty took effect 27 August 2025 (EO 14329); the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 (EO 14384) and the IEEPA additional duties, including the reciprocal duty, were ended by EO 14389 in February 2026; a separate 10% Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026. India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action "unjustified and unreasonable" (4 and 6 August 2025). ANALYSIS: Treat these as dated, reversible executive measures - not as settled trade policy.

- CURRENT: **23rd India-Russia Annual Summit (New Delhi, 4-5 December 2025):** held during President Putin's state visit; joint statement titled "Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust & Mutual Respect," with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted.

- CURRENT: **India-China border management:** on 21 October 2024 MEA announced "an agreement... on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control... leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020," later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok. The 23rd Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the 24th in New Delhi on 19 August 2025, agreeing an Expert Group on "early harvest" boundary delimitation, a WMCC working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors; the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025. ANALYSIS: These are patrolling and process arrangements - not a boundary settlement.

- ANALYSIS: **China trade relationship:** managed through ongoing commercial engagement without a comparable strategic framework agreement, given the unresolved boundary dispute - Economy owns tariff/trade-deficit mechanics.

India-US and India-Russia defence architecture

- FACT: **India-US enabling agreements:** LEMOA (2016) enables reciprocal logistics support; COMCASA (2018) enables secure communications; BECA (2020) enables exchange of geospatial information. **Significance:** together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness. **Limitation:** they are enabling agreements, not a collective-defence alliance or automatic basing right.

- FACT: **Major Defence Partner:** the United States designated India a Major

Defence Partner in **2016**; the ten-year Framework for the US-India Major Defense Partnership was signed on **31 October 2025**. **Significance:** the relationship now combines procurement, exercises, industrial cooperation and technology access. **Limitation:** export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition delivery.

- **FACT: India-Russia installed base:** Su-30MKI licensed production and the

BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement; the 2018 S-400 contract is a named high-end acquisition. **Significance:** Russia remains embedded in India's operational inventory and maintenance ecosystem. **Limitation:** installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence risk even when the overall relationship is described as complementary.

- **FACT: AK-203 joint venture:** the Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited venture at

Korwa represents an attempt to localise production. **Significance:** joint production can convert buyer-seller ties into industrial capacity. **Limitation:** localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately.

- **ANALYSIS: CAATSA exposure:** the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible US

sanctions under another state's domestic law. **Significance:** third-party sanctions can narrow strategic-autonomy choices. **Limitation:** exposure is not the same as an international-law obligation on India.

India-Japan and India-EU diversification pillars

- **FACT: India-Japan strategic upgrade:** the relationship was elevated to a

Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014. The third Foreign and Defence Ministers' 2+2 meeting met in New Delhi on **20 August 2024** and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation.

Significance: Japan supplies a combined security, infrastructure, technology and Indo-Pacific pillar outside a treaty alliance. **Limitation:** implementation pace and Japan's own security constraints prevent the partnership from substituting for Indian capability.

- **FACT: Reciprocal logistics support:** the India-Japan Agreement concerning

Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in **September 2020** and became operational in 2021.

Significance: it enables practical defence interoperability and expands the geographic reach of exercises and HADR cooperation. **Limitation:** logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment.

- **FACT: Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail:** JICA records cumulative commitments

exceeding **JPY 1 trillion since 2017**, alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation.

Significance: the project converts strategic partnership into long-term infrastructure and technology transfer.

Limitation: concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risks.

- **FACT: Supply Chain Resilience Initiative:** Australia, India and Japan launched

SCRI in **April 2021** to promote diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching. **Significance:** it translates

de-risking from China into a plurilateral economic instrument. **Limitation:** dialogue and matching mechanisms do not themselves establish relocated production.

- **ANALYSIS: India-EU pillar:** the EU-India Trade and Technology Council creates a

channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation. FTA negotiations concluded on **27 January**

2026, but legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force. **Significance:** the EU widens

India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond US-China competition. **Limitation:** regulatory differences and an agreement not yet in force constrain immediate gains.

5. Indian applications and examples

Russia-Ukraine conflict and India's interests

- **FACT:** Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022. India

has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance, and generally abstained on polarising UN resolutions rather than joining either bloc.

- **ANALYSIS: Energy and fertiliser:** disrupted European-Russian trade redirected discounted

Russian supplies toward India, supporting energy and farm-input security. The gain is qualified by sanctions exposure, payment/logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure.

- ANALYSIS: **Defence:** legacy Russian-origin platforms make spares and maintenance a security concern; diversification reduces future concentration but cannot instantly replace an installed equipment base.

- ANALYSIS: **Diplomacy:** India's position demonstrates strategic autonomy and preserves access to Russia while maintaining Western technology partnerships. The limitation is reputational criticism and reduced room for explicit norm-enforcement.

- ANALYSIS: **Global spillovers:** Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; India must separate humanitarian/UN-Charter principles from its national-interest management of supplies.

- FACT: **Direct PYQ (2024 Q9, local paper text reproduced verbatim):** "The West is fostering India as an alternative to reduce dependence on China's supply chain and as a strategically to counter China's political and economic dominance." Explain this statement with examples.* (10 marks, 150 words) - the apparent grammatical/spelling defects in the supplied paper text are retained rather than silently corrected.

- ANALYSIS: A strong answer to 2024 Q9 should cite iCET (17 June 2024 review) and the clean-energy supply-chain commitments (21 September 2024) as concrete examples of the West "fostering India as an alternative," updated with TRUST/COMPACT (13 February 2025) and the ten-year US-India Major Defense Partnership framework (31 October 2025), while noting the risk (flagged in the master framework's boundary-blindness gap) of overstating this as India "replacing" China rather than diversifying supply-chain dependence. ANALYSIS: The 2025-26 US tariff cycle is the strongest counter-evidence to a one-way "fostering" reading and should be acknowledged.

- ANALYSIS: Sikri's mistrust framing and Tharoor's "tactical partnership" caution (India-US relationship should be seen "as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests," not an alliance) both support treating supply-chain diversification as an interest-convergence opportunity, not a binding alliance commitment.

6. Must-Know Facts for Prelims

- FACT: iCET was announced in May 2022; its inaugural NSA-level meeting was held on 31 January 2023 and a second NSA-level review on 17 June 2024.

- CURRENT: India-US clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced 21 September 2024.

- CURRENT: TRUST ("Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology") and COMPACT ("Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce & Technology") were both announced on 13 February 2025.

- CURRENT: The Framework for the US-India Major Defense Partnership - a ten-year framework - was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025.

- CURRENT: The India-China patrolling arrangement covering Depsang and Demchok was announced by MEA on 21 October 2024; the 23rd and 24th Special Representatives rounds were held on 18 December 2024 (Beijing) and 19 August 2025 (New Delhi).

- CURRENT: The 23rd India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4-5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit.

- FACT: Sikri's book-period assessment described China as India's largest trading partner despite an unresolved boundary dispute and persistent strategic mistrust; a current ranking requires current official trade data.

- FACT: Russia remains, per Sikri, a supplier of high-technology defence equipment (including nuclear-powered submarines) unavailable to India from other sources.

- FACT: Tharoor identifies continuing restrictions on US high-technology exports to India as unresolved friction even amid deepening strategic convergence.

- ANALYSIS: De-risking (reducing overconcentration) is analytically distinct from decoupling (full disengagement); India's China policy is de-risking, not decoupling.

7. UPSC traps

- WRONG: The West's supply-chain diversification toward India means India is

"replacing" China. -> It means diversifying dependence, not substitution; China remains a major trading partner even as alternative capacity develops elsewhere.

- WRONG: India-US technology cooperation constitutes a formal military alliance. ->

iCET and defence-industrial cooperation are partnership frameworks, not a mutual-defence treaty; Tharoor explicitly frames the relationship as "tactical," not alliance-bound.

- WRONG: India's deepening Russia ties are incompatible with deepening US ties. ->

Strategic autonomy/hedging (topic 01) allows both to proceed on separate interest logics (defence-energy complementarity with Russia; technology convergence with the US).

- WRONG: Trade volume with China implies strategic trust. -> Sikri explicitly

separates the two: high trade volume coexists with "enduring mistrust and suspicion" rooted in the unresolved boundary dispute.

- WRONG: Critical-mineral and semiconductor cooperation are purely economic

(Economy-only) matters. -> Their strategic/security dimension (supply-chain resilience, technology-access diplomacy) is IR's domain; Economy owns the trade and production mechanics.

- WRONG: The October 2024 patrolling arrangement settled the India-China boundary.

-> MEA's own wording covers "patrolling arrangements... leading to disengagement," specified as Depsang and Demchok; the boundary question continues in the Special Representatives channel, with an Expert Group on "early harvest" delimitation agreed only on 19 August 2025.

- WRONG: TRUST replaced iCET, and the 2025 defence framework is an alliance treaty.

-> The official 13 February 2025 statement does not say TRUST terminated iCET, and the 31 October 2025 instrument is a ten-year *framework* for a major defence partnership, not a mutual-defence treaty.

- WRONG: US tariff measures on India are a fixed feature of the relationship. ->

The 2025-26 measures were executive-order-based and were varied and then removed within months; cite the specific order and effective date rather than a standing rate.

8. CURRENT: Current anchor

- CURRENT: For the technology track, cite **TRUST/COMPACT (13 February 2025)** and the

Framework for the US-India Major Defense Partnership (31 October 2025) alongside the earlier **iCET review (17 June 2024)** and **clean-energy supply-chain commitments (21 September 2024)**. For the China track, cite the **patrolling arrangement of 21 October 2024** and the **24th Special Representatives round (19 August 2025)**. For the Russia track, cite the **23rd India-Russia Annual Summit (4-5 December 2025)**. ANALYSIS: Together these three dated tracks are the evidence that India's hedge is being run simultaneously, not sequentially.

9. PYQ application

- FACT: **2024 Q9 (direct; local paper text reproduced verbatim):** "The West is

fostering India as an alternative to reduce dependence on China's supply chain and as a strategically to counter China's political and economic dominance." Explain this statement with examples.* Structure the answer: (1) define friend-shoring/de-risking; (2) cite iCET (17 June 2024 review), clean-energy supply-chain commitments (21 September 2024) and TRUST/COMPACT (13 February 2025) as concrete examples; (3) note the risk of overstating this as "replacement" rather than diversification, and cite the 2025-26 US tariff cycle as evidence that "fostering" is conditional and reversible; (4) close with the strategic- autonomy point that India pursues this without abandoning China trade or Russia defence/energy ties (23rd Annual Summit, 4-5 December 2025).

10. Mains angles

- ANALYSIS: Separate the economic-interdependence and strategic-mistrust dimensions of India-China relations explicitly - conflating them is a common scoring error.
- ANALYSIS: Use "tactical partnership," not "alliance," to describe India-US convergence, per Tharoor's own framing caution.
- ANALYSIS: Use "complementarity" for the overall India-Russia relationship, while naming the narrower **installed-base/spares dependence** precisely.
- ANALYSIS: Always distinguish de-risking from decoupling when discussing supply-chain policy.

Answer thesis: India manages structurally different major-power relationships - economic interdependence with strategic mistrust toward China, technology-led tactical convergence with the US, and defence-energy complementarity with Russia - by channelling Western supply-chain diversification interest into concrete, dated instruments like iCET, without treating any single relationship as an exclusive alliance or abandoning the others.

11. Probable questions

- ANALYSIS: **Prelims:** On what date was the second India-US iCET meeting/review held in 2024?
- FACT: **Mains (10 marks, direct 2024 PYQ; local text verbatim):** "The West is fostering India as an alternative to reduce dependence on China's supply chain and as a strategically to counter China's political and economic dominance." Explain this statement with examples.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (15 marks):** Distinguish India's economic engagement with China from its strategic posture toward China. How does this distinction shape India's supply-chain diversification policy?

11A. Answer architecture (10/15/20-mark support)

Direct Mains demands owned by Core

Core owns the 2019 India-Japan and India-US demands and the 2021 China challenge demand, superseding the older advanced/03 routes.

- **Major-power matrix:** China--trade plus boundary mistrust; US--technology/security convergence plus policy volatility; Russia--defence/energy continuity plus sanctions exposure; Japan/EU--capital, standards, connectivity and resilient supply chains.
- **Ukraine engine:** principles -> UN posture -> energy/fertiliser -> defence spares -> sanctions exposure -> diplomatic balance.

10 marks: precise bilateral thesis and 2-3 dated instruments. **15 marks:** interests, convergence, friction and third-party effects with 4-6 examples. **20 marks:** compare all major-power tracks, dependencies, supply chains, technology controls, conflicts and strategic-autonomy choices.

Reasoned verdict: India's major-power policy is successful when diversified partnerships expand capability without converting any one dependence into a veto over national choices.

12. Study links

- FACT: Advanced companion:
advanced/03_India-China-Major-Powers-and-Resilient-Supply-Chains.md.
- FACT: Economy/basic/20_Foreign-Trade-WTO-FTAs-and-Protectionism.md - trade and tariff mechanics (Economy owns this detail).
- FACT: 00_Master-Framework.md Section 4 - the strategic-autonomy framework underlying hedged major-power engagement.

- ANALYSIS: **Cross-links within this folder:** topic 01 for the hedging vocabulary; topic 11 for globalisation/de-risking as a systemic trend; topic 12 for China's role in UN Security Council reform debates.

2026 PYQ Integration

Status: 2026 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2026.md. **Answer-key rule:** The 2026 Prelims and CSAT Set-A keys held locally are **provisional**; no option or answer is recorded or inferred in this integration.

- **Year represented:** 2026
- **Paper(s):** Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2026	Prelims GS-I	78	India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation, and Indo-Pacific dialogue	Objective question; provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally, answer not inferred	Provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally (Ans - 2026 - GS1 - Provisional); key is provisional - no answer letter recorded or inferred here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation, and Indo-Pacific dialogue

This block integrates the 2026 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 and 2024-2025 blocks and does not convert a provisionally-keyed, answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

Recent PYQ Integration (2024-2025)

Status: 2024-2025 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2024-2025.md.

- **Years represented:** 2024
- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2024	GS-II	9	West fostering India as an alternative to China's supply chain	Explain · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- West fostering India as an alternative to China's supply chain

This block integrates the 2024-2025 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 block and does not convert an unkeyed/answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md, _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2018-2023.md. **Answer-key rule:** The official 2018-2023 Prelims/CSAT keys are not held locally; no option or answer has been inferred.

- **Years represented:** 2019, 2021

- **Paper(s):** GS-II, Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 4

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2019	GS-II	9	India-Japan contemporary global and strategic partnership	Comment · 10 marks · 150 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2019	GS-II	20	Friction in India-US ties and India's place in US global strategy	Explain with suitable examples · 15 marks · 250 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2019	Prelims GS-I	89	India nuclear field cooperation bilateral action plan	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2021	GS-II	10	The USA facing an existential challenge from China	Explain · 10 marks · 150 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- India-Japan contemporary global and strategic partnership
- Friction in India-US ties and India's place in US global strategy
- India nuclear field cooperation bilateral action plan
- The USA facing an existential challenge from China

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

CLOSING RECALL FLOW - CORE SYNTHESIS - UKRAINE POSTURE, MINILATERAL BALANCING AND HONEST QUESTION OWNERSHIP

START / CONCEPT: CORE SYNTHESIS - Ukraine posture, minilateral balancing and honest question ownership

|
v

EXACT TERMS: CORE SYNTHESIS · Ukraine posture · minilateral balancing · honest question ownership · Evidence chain · Qualified use

|
v

MECHANISM / ARGUMENT: Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

|
v

CONSEQUENCE / CONTRAST: Strategic-autonomy filter applied: each relationship is pursued on its own interest logic (topic 01) - deepening US technology ties does not require ending Russian defence/energy ties or abandoning China trade engagement.

|
v

UPSC TRAP / ANSWER-USE: Limitation: exposure is not the same as an international-law obligation on India.

|
v

ANSWER-GRABBING FORMULATION: Evidence chain: The Ukraine posture, minilateral balancing and honest question ownership Qualified use: Close with the systemic frame, the coordination limit and an explicit ownership boundary.

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS DEEP-REVIEW CORE CONTROL

- **Must remember:** India's relations with China and other major powers combine border security, deterrence, diplomacy, technology, trade, investment, defence, energy and resilient supply chains; cooperation and competition can coexist across separate domains.
- **Close distinction:** Border claim, Line of Actual Control perception, agreed boundary, ceasefire arrangement and final settlement are not synonyms; diversification is not decoupling, de-risking is not autarky, and a partnership or foundational agreement is not automatically a military alliance.
- **Status / evidence / implementation limit:** Distinguish announced initiative, signed agreement, ratified treaty where applicable, operative mechanism and measured outcome; qualify causal claims about supply-chain shifts, sanctions, technology controls and trade dependence with sector, date and alternative explanations.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Q1. Which statement correctly identifies What this owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?

A. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. B. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the

relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. C. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. D. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner.

Answer: A. Explanation: This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q2. Which card should be filed under What this owner holds and how its boundaries are routed in an International Relations answer?

A. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. B. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. C. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. D. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner.

Answer: B. Explanation: This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four

General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q3. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of What this owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?

A. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. B. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. C. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. D. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India.

Answer: C. Explanation: This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q4. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about What this owner holds and how its boundaries are routed?

A. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. B. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative,

so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. C. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. D. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12.

Answer: D. Explanation: This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q5. Which statement correctly identifies The India-China economic-strategic paradox?

A. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. B. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. C. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. D. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale.

Answer: A. Explanation: In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade

volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q6. Which card should be filed under The India-China economic-strategic paradox in an International Relations answer?

A. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. B. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. C. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. D. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale.

Answer: B. Explanation: In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q7. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The India-China economic-strategic paradox?

A. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. B. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. C. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time

India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. D. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier.

Answer: C. Explanation: In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q8. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The India-China economic-strategic paradox?

A. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. B. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. C. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated ICET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. D. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement.

Answer: D. Explanation: In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q9. Which statement correctly identifies Trade-pattern asymmetry as an economic grievance layered on strategic mistrust?

A. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. B. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. C. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. D. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India.

Answer: A. Explanation: Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q10. Which card should be filed under Trade-pattern asymmetry as an economic grievance layered on strategic mistrust in an International Relations answer?

A. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. B. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. C. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. D. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically

aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale.

Answer: B. Explanation: Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q11. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Trade-pattern asymmetry as an economic grievance layered on strategic mistrust?

A. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. B. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. C. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. D. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India.

Answer: C. Explanation: Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q12. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Trade-pattern asymmetry as an economic grievance layered on strategic mistrust?

A. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. B. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. C. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated ICET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. D. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track.

Answer: D. Explanation: Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q13. Which statement correctly identifies De-risking against decoupling?

A. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. B. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. C. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. D. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a

tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India.

Answer: A. Explanation: De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q14. Which card should be filed under De-risking against decoupling in an International Relations answer?

A. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. B. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. C. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. D. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations.

Answer: B. Explanation: De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q15. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of De-risking against decoupling?

A. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. B. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. C. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. D. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations.

Answer: C. Explanation: De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q16. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about De-risking against decoupling?

A. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. B. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. C. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. D. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year

undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner.

Answer: D. Explanation: De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q17. Which statement correctly identifies Friend-shoring and trusted supply chains as the Western policy logic?

A. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. B. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. C. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. D. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations.

Answer: A. Explanation: Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q18. Which card should be filed under Friend-shoring and trusted supply chains as the Western policy logic in an International Relations answer?

A. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. B. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. C. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. D. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available.

Answer: B. Explanation: Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q19. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Friend-shoring and trusted supply chains as the Western policy logic?

A. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. B. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. C. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. D. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the

Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession.

Answer: C. Explanation: Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q20. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Friend-shoring and trusted supply chains as the Western policy logic?

A. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. B. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. C. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. D. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale.

Answer: D. Explanation: Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q21. Which statement correctly identifies The United States track as technology-led tactical convergence?

A. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. B. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. C. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. D. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations.

Answer: A. Explanation: Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q22. Which card should be filed under The United States track as technology-led tactical convergence in an International Relations answer?

A. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. B. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. C. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. D. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial

cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations.

Answer: B. Explanation: Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q23. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The United States track as technology-led tactical convergence?

A. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. B. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. C. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. D. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment.

Answer: C. Explanation: Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q24. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The United States track as technology-led tactical convergence?

A. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. B. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of

geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. C. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. D. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India.

Answer: D. Explanation: Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q25. Which statement correctly identifies Technology-access asymmetry as unresolved friction?

A. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. B. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. C. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. D. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession.

Answer: A. Explanation: Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q26. Which card should be filed under Technology-access asymmetry as unresolved friction in an International Relations answer?

A. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. B. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. C. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. D. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available.

Answer: B. Explanation: Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q27. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Technology-access asymmetry as unresolved friction?

A. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. B. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. C. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. D. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and

the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment.

Answer: C. Explanation: Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q28. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Technology-access asymmetry as unresolved friction?

A. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. B. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. C. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. D. Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier.

Answer: D. Explanation: Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q29. Which statement correctly identifies The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology and its exact status?

A. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. B. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. C. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. D. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available.

Answer: A. Explanation: The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q30. Which card should be filed under The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology and its exact status in an International Relations answer?

A. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. B. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. C. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. D. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership,

Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession.

Answer: B. Explanation: The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q31. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology and its exact status?

A. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. B. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. C. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. D. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment.

Answer: C. Explanation: The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q32. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology and its exact status?

A. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. B. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. C. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. D. The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations.

Answer: D. Explanation: The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q33. Which statement correctly identifies Clean-energy supply-chain commitments of September 2024?

A. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. B. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. C. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an

automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. D. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment.

Answer: A. Explanation: India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q34. Which card should be filed under Clean-energy supply-chain commitments of September 2024 in an International Relations answer?

A. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. B. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. C. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. D. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery.

Answer: B. Explanation: India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q35. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Clean-energy supply-chain commitments of September 2024?

A. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. B. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. C. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. D. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery.

Answer: C. Explanation: India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q36. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Clean-energy supply-chain commitments of September 2024?

A. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. B. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. C. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy

complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. D. India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available.

Answer: D. Explanation: India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q37. Which statement correctly identifies TRUST, COMPACT and Mission 500 of February 2025?

A. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. B. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. C. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. D. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks.

Answer: A. Explanation: Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q38. Which card should be filed under TRUST, COMPACT and Mission 500 of February 2025 in an International Relations answer?

A. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. B. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. C. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. D. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India.

Answer: B. Explanation: Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q39. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of TRUST, COMPACT and Mission 500 of February 2025?

A. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. B. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. C. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for

critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. D. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority.

Answer: C. Explanation: Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q40. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about TRUST, COMPACT and Mission 500 of February 2025?

A. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. B. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. C. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. D. Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession.

Answer: D. Explanation: Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic

Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q41. Which statement correctly identifies The ten-year defence framework of October 2025 and its non-treaty character?

A. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. B. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. C. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. D. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery.

Answer: A. Explanation: The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q42. Which card should be filed under The ten-year defence framework of October 2025 and its non-treaty character in an International Relations answer?

A. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. B. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated

India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. C. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. D. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India.

Answer: B. Explanation: The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q43. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The ten-year defence framework of October 2025 and its non-treaty character?

A. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. B. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. C. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. D. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement.

Answer: C. Explanation: The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a

framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q44. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The ten-year defence framework of October 2025 and its non-treaty character?

A. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. B. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. C. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. D. The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment.

Answer: D. Explanation: The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q45. Which statement correctly identifies The enabling-agreement architecture and what it does not create?

A. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. B. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. C. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. D. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks.

Answer: A. Explanation: The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q46. Which card should be filed under The enabling-agreement architecture and what it does not create in an International Relations answer?

A. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. B. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. C. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production

milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. D. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement.

Answer: B. Explanation: The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q47. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The enabling-agreement architecture and what it does not create?

A. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. B. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. C. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. D. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and

coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy.

Answer: C. Explanation: The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q48. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The enabling-agreement architecture and what it does not create?

A. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. B. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. C. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. D. The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery.

Answer: D. Explanation: The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation

directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q49. Which statement correctly identifies Russia as defence-energy complementarity rather than one-sided dependence?

A. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. B. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. C. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. D. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement.

Answer: A. Explanation: Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q50. Which card should be filed under Russia as defence-energy complementarity rather than one-sided dependence in an International Relations answer?

A. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. B. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere,

including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. C. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. D. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement.

Answer: B. Explanation: Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q51. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of Russia as defence-energy complementarity rather than one-sided dependence?

A. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. B. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. C. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower

installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. D. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement.

Answer: C. Explanation: Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q52. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about Russia as defence-energy complementarity rather than one-sided dependence?

A. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. B. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. C. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. D. Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks.

Answer: D. Explanation: Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign

military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q53. Which statement correctly identifies The Russian installed base, joint production and third-party sanctions exposure?

A. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. B. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. C. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. D. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy.

Answer: A. Explanation: Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q54. Which card should be filed under The Russian installed base, joint production and third-party sanctions exposure in an International Relations answer?

A. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. B. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. C. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. D. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy.

Answer: B. Explanation: Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q55. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Russian installed base, joint production and third-party sanctions exposure?

A. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. B. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. C. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. D. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains.

Answer: C. Explanation: Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q56. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Russian installed base, joint production and third-party sanctions exposure?

A. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. B. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for

dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. C. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. D. Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India.

Answer: D. Explanation: Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q57. Which statement correctly identifies The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit of December 2025?

A. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. B. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics

access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. C. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Dopsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. D. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy.

Answer: A. Explanation: The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q58. Which card should be filed under The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit of December 2025 in an International Relations answer?

A. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. B. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. C. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment,

that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. D. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains.

Answer: B. Explanation: The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q59. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit of December 2025?

A. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. B. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. C. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. D. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains.

Answer: C. Explanation: The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q60. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit of December 2025?

A. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. B. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. C. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. D. The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority.

Answer: D. Explanation: The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q61. Which statement correctly identifies The India-China border and dialogue architecture as process, not settlement?

A. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. B. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. C. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. D. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy.

Answer: A. Explanation: On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q62. Which card should be filed under The India-China border and dialogue architecture as process, not settlement in an International Relations answer?

A. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. B. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. C. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. D. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

Answer: B. Explanation: On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q63. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The India-China border and dialogue architecture as process, not settlement?

A. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. B. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. C. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. D. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

Answer: C. Explanation: On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q64. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The India-China border and dialogue architecture as process, not settlement?

A. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. B. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. C. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. D. On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement.

Answer: D. Explanation: On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q65. Which statement correctly identifies The United States tariff cycle of 2025-26 as an architecture stress test?

A. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. B. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. C. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. D. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

Answer: A. Explanation: An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q66. Which card should be filed under The United States tariff cycle of 2025-26 as an architecture stress test in an International Relations answer?

A. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. B. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. C. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. D. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains.

Answer: B. Explanation: An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q67. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The United States tariff cycle of 2025-26 as an architecture stress test?

A. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. B. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. C. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. D. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

Answer: C. Explanation: An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q68. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The United States tariff cycle of 2025-26 as an architecture stress test?

A. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. B. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. C. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. D. An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy.

Answer: D. Explanation: An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q69. Which statement correctly identifies The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security, infrastructure and technology partner?

A. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. B. The European Union-India Trade

and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. C. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. D. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12.

Answer: A. Explanation: The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q70. Which card should be filed under The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security, infrastructure and technology partner in an International Relations answer?

A. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. B. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and

technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. C. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. D. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12.

Answer: B. Explanation: The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q71. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security, infrastructure and technology partner?

A. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. B. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. C. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and

Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. D. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track.

Answer: C. Explanation: The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q72. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security, infrastructure and technology partner?

A. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. B. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. C. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. D. The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production.

Answer: D. Explanation: The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q73. Which statement correctly identifies The European Union pillar and the not-yet-in-force qualification?

A. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. B. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. C. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. D. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement.

Answer: A. Explanation: The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. The remaining options

Q74. Which card should be filed under The European Union pillar and the not-yet-in-force qualification in an International Relations answer?

A. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. B. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. C. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. D. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement.

Answer: B. Explanation: The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q75. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The European Union pillar and the not-yet-in-force qualification?

A. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. B. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. C. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on

27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. D. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner.

Answer: C. Explanation: The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q76. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The European Union pillar and the not-yet-in-force qualification?

A. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. B. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. C. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. D. The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains.

Answer: D. Explanation: The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q77. Which statement correctly identifies The Ukraine posture, minilateral balancing and honest question ownership?

A. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. B. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. C. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. D. This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12.

Answer: A. Explanation: Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q78. Which card should be filed under The Ukraine posture, minilateral balancing and honest question ownership in an International Relations answer?

A. In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. B. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. C. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. D. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner.

Answer: B. Explanation: Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q79. Which option preserves the source-bounded meaning of The Ukraine posture, minilateral balancing and honest question ownership?

A. Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. B. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. C. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. D. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale.

Answer: C. Explanation: Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

Q80. Which statement avoids a close-option trap about The Ukraine posture, minilateral balancing and honest question ownership?

A. Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. B. Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. C. De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. D. Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

Answer: D. Explanation: Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. The remaining options belong to different actors, instruments, evidentiary levels or analytical categories.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT

Four General Studies Paper II Mains demands are routed to this topic in the audited routing ledgers and each is reproduced below as a demand card with its printed year, paper, question number, directive, marks and word limit exactly as the ledger records them: 2019 General Studies Paper II question 9 on the India-Japan contemporary global and strategic partnership, a Comment demand of 10 marks and 150 words; 2019 General Studies Paper II question 20 on friction in India-United States ties and India's place in United States global strategy, an Explain with suitable examples demand of 15 marks and 250 words; 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 on the United States facing an existential challenge from China, an Explain demand of 10 marks and 150 words; and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9 on the West fostering India as an alternative to China's supply chain, an Explain demand of 10 marks and 150 words. For the three 2019 and 2021 demands the ledger records that the Core route supersedes the older Advanced ownership and that the word limits are taken from the instruction block. Two objective demands are also routed to this owner and are carried as coverage requirements only: 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan, for which the official key is not held locally, and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which only a provisional 2026 Set-A key is present locally. No option or answer letter is recorded or inferred for either objective demand, and the provisional status of the 2026 key is preserved exactly. The supplied paper text of the 2024 demand carries apparent grammatical and spelling defects, and the owners require that it be reproduced as printed rather than silently corrected, which is done in the corresponding demand card below. The locally held OCR-searchable official General Studies papers were read only to confirm the printed wording of the routed Mains demands; no question was invented from them, no stem was paraphrased into an apparent routing, and no marking scheme or page precision was imported. Every model solution below is original work written to the repository's examiner-grade standard using the claim, named evidence, analysis and qualification pattern, and none of them reproduces or claims an official answer.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The answer must resolve the International Relations demand in "VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT".

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Define the foreign-policy concept and distinguish the nearest doctrine, grouping, treaty or operational category. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Map India's interests, capabilities and constraints against the partner's agency at bilateral, regional and systemic levels. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Identify the exact treaty, institution, corridor, agreement, operation or summit with membership, mandate, date and status. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Trace strategic objective, selected instrument, implementing actors, resources, bottleneck, output and outcome. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed

status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

5. **Claim and named evidence:** Use named India-centric diplomatic, security, trade, connectivity, diaspora or development evidence without event-listing. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

6. **Claim and named evidence:** Test dependence, escalation, legitimacy, domestic distribution, financing, partner divergence, alternatives and residual risk. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The answer must resolve the International Relations demand in "VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT".

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "VERIFIED PYQ OWNERSHIP AUDIT", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

OWNER PYQ LEDGER EXTRACTS

9. PYQ application

- **FACT: 2024 Q9 (direct; local paper text reproduced verbatim):** "The West is

fostering India as an alternative to reduce dependence on China's supply chain and as a strategically to counter China's political and economic dominance." Explain this statement with examples.* Structure the answer: (1) define friend-shoring/de-risking; (2) cite iCET (17 June 2024 review), clean-energy supply-chain commitments (21 September 2024) and TRUST/COMPACT (13 February 2025) as concrete examples; (3) note the risk of overstating this as "replacement" rather than diversification, and cite the 2025-26 US tariff cycle as evidence that "fostering" is conditional and reversible; (4) close with the strategic- autonomy point that India pursues this without abandoning China trade or Russia defence/energy ties (23rd Annual Summit, 4-5 December 2025).

2026 PYQ Integration

Status: 2026 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2026.md. **Answer-key rule:** The 2026 Prelims and CSAT Set-A keys held locally are **provisional**; no option or answer is recorded or inferred in this integration.

- **Year represented:** 2026
- **Paper(s):** Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2026	Prelims GS-I	78	India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation, and Indo-Pacific dialogue	Objective question; provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally, answer not inferred	Provisional 2026 Set-A key present locally (Ans - 2026 - GS1 - Provisional); key is provisional - no answer letter recorded or inferred here	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.

What this owner must now support

- India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation, and Indo-Pacific dialogue

This block integrates the 2026 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 and 2024-2025 blocks and does not convert a provisionally-keyed, answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

Recent PYQ Integration (2024-2025)

Status: 2024-2025 question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2024-2025.md.

- **Years represented:** 2024
- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 1

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2024	GS-II	9	West fostering India as an alternative to China's supply chain	Explain · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- West fostering India as an alternative to China's supply chain

This block integrates the 2024-2025 examinable demand and paper metadata. It is kept separate from the 2018-2023 block and does not convert an unkeyed/answer-free objective question into a solved answer.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md, _PYQ-ROUTING-PRELIMS-2018-2023.md. **Answer-key rule:** The official 2018-2023 Prelims/CSAT keys are not held locally; no option or answer has been inferred.

- **Years represented:** 2019, 2021
- **Paper(s):** GS-II, Prelims GS-I
- **Routed question demands:** 4

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2019	GS-II	9	India-Japan contemporary global and strategic partnership	Comment · 10 marks · 150 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2019	GS-II	20	Friction in India-US ties and India's place in US global strategy	Explain with suitable examples · 15 marks · 250 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2019	Prelims GS-I	89	India nuclear field cooperation bilateral action plan	Objective question; official key unavailable locally	Routed; key unavailable locally	Cover the named fact/concept and its likely statement-level distinctions.
2021	GS-II	10	The USA facing an existential challenge from China	Explain · 10 marks · 150 words	Core route supersedes older Advanced ownership	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- India-Japan contemporary global and strategic partnership
- Friction in India-US ties and India's place in US global strategy
- India nuclear field cooperation bilateral action plan
- The USA facing an existential challenge from China

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

10. PYQ-based analytical application

- **FACT: 2024 Q9 (direct; local paper text reproduced verbatim):** "The West is fostering India as an alternative to reduce dependence on China's supply chain and as a strategically to counter China's political and economic dominance." Explain this statement with examples.* An advanced-level answer should:
 1. Separate the economic (diversification opportunity) and strategic (mistrust of China) dimensions explicitly.
 2. Cite ICET (17 June 2024 review), the clean-energy supply-chain commitments (21 September 2024) and TRUST/COMPACT (13 February 2025) as concrete evidence.
 3. Qualify the "counter China's dominance" framing - India pursues diversification, not an anti-China alliance, and sustains simultaneous China engagement (the 24th SR round, 19 August 2025) and Russia defence-energy ties (23rd Annual Summit, 4-5 December 2025).
 4. Flag the autonomy-dependence trade-off if the US-technology track deepens without reciprocal technology-sharing, and cite the 2025-26 US tariff cycle as evidence that "fostering" is conditional and reversible.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2019, 2021
- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 3

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2019	GS-II	9	India-Japan contemporary global and strategic partnership	Comment · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic; word limit taken from the instruction block	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2019	GS-II	20	Friction in India-US ties and India's place in US global strategy	Explain with suitable examples · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic; word limit taken from the instruction block	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2021	GS-II	10	The USA facing an existential challenge from China	Explain · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- India-Japan contemporary global and strategic partnership
- Friction in India-US ties and India's place in US global strategy
- The USA facing an existential challenge from China

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2019 General Studies Paper II Question 9

Demand: The India-Japan contemporary global and strategic partnership, a Comment demand of 10 marks and 150 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger with the word limit taken from the instruction block.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

Model solution: Claim: the India-Japan partnership is best commented upon as a non-treaty partnership that delivers security, infrastructure and technology simultaneously, which is precisely what makes it valuable to a state pursuing diversification without alliance. Named evidence and example: elevation to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014; the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting in New Delhi on 20 August 2024, which agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation; the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services signed in September 2020 and operational from 2021; Japan International Cooperation Agency commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail with Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation; and the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative launched with Australia in April 2021. Analysis: each instrument occupies a different level of the toolkit, since the two-plus-two is a political and defence consultation mechanism, the supplies agreement is an enabling instrument that extends the geographic reach of exercises and humanitarian assistance, the rail commitment converts partnership into long-term infrastructure and technology transfer, and the resilience initiative translates de-risking into a plurilateral economic instrument, so the partnership is broad precisely because no single instrument carries a treaty obligation. Qualification: the comment must not overstate any of these, because logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production, and Japan's own security constraints and implementation pace prevent the partnership from substituting for Indian capability. Why this earns marks: it answers the Comment directive by making an evaluative judgement about the partnership's character rather than listing its milestones, and it prices each instrument at its exact evidentiary level.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2019 General Studies Paper II Question 9", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives,

implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: the India-Japan partnership is best commented upon as a non-treaty partnership that delivers security, infrastructure and technology simultaneously, which is precisely what makes it valuable to a state pursuing diversification without alliance. Named evidence and example: elevation to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014; the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting in New Delhi on 20 August 2024, which agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation; the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services signed in September 2020 and operational from 2021; Japan International Cooperation Agency commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail with Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation; and the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative launched with Australia in April 2021. Analysis: each instrument occupies a different level of the toolkit, since the two-plus-two is a political and defence consultation mechanism, the supplies agreement is an enabling instrument that extends the geographic reach of exercises and humanitarian assistance, the rail commitment converts partnership into long-term infrastructure and technology transfer, and the resilience initiative translates de-risking into a plurilateral economic instrument, so the partnership is broad precisely because no single instrument carries a treaty obligation. Qualification: the comment must not overstate any of these, because logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production, and Japan's own security constraints and implementation pace prevent the partnership from substituting for Indian capability. Why this earns marks: it answers the Comment directive by making an evaluative judgement about the partnership's character rather than listing its milestones, and it prices each instrument at its exact evidentiary level.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2019 General Studies Paper II Question 9 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: the India-Japan partnership is best commented upon as a non-treaty partnership that delivers security, infrastructure and technology simultaneously, which is precisely what makes it valuable to a state pursuing diversification without alliance. Named evidence and example: elevation to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014; the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting in New Delhi on 20 August 2024, which agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation; the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services signed in September 2020 and operational from 2021; Japan International Cooperation Agency commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail with Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation; and the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative launched with Australia in April 2021. Analysis: each instrument occupies a different level of the toolkit, since the two-plus-two is a political and defence consultation mechanism, the supplies agreement is an enabling instrument that extends the geographic reach of exercises and humanitarian assistance, the rail commitment converts partnership into long-term infrastructure and technology transfer, and the resilience initiative translates de-risking into a plurilateral economic instrument, so the partnership is broad precisely because no single instrument carries a treaty obligation. Qualification: the comment must not overstate any of these, because logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production, and Japan's own security constraints and implementation pace prevent the partnership from substituting for Indian capability. Why this earns marks: it answers the Comment directive by making an evaluative judgement about the partnership's character rather than listing its milestones, and it prices each instrument at its exact evidentiary level.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write

four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For “PYQ DEMAND CARD 1 - 2019 General Studies Paper II Question 9”, replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2019 General Studies Paper II Question 20

Demand: Friction in India-United States ties and India's place in United States global strategy, an Explain with suitable examples demand of 15 marks and 250 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger with the word limit taken from the instruction block.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

Model solution: Claim: friction persists inside a deepening relationship because India's place in United States global strategy is instrumental rather than allied, so convergence and coercion can operate at the same time. Named evidence and example: Tharoor's recommendation to view the relationship as a tactical partnership serving both countries' short-term interests together with his caution against hyperbole; his separate record of continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India; the enabling architecture of the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020; the 2016 Major Defence Partner designation and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025; and the tariff sequence in which a twenty-five per cent reciprocal duty took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326, an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329 and was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, with a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty from 24 July 2026 and India's official description of the Russian-oil-linked action as unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025. Analysis: the enabling agreements raise interoperability, logistics and situational awareness without creating an obligation, which is exactly the arrangement a state seeking freedom of action wants, but the same absence of obligation leaves India exposed to unilateral measures that a treaty ally would contest through alliance machinery; technology-access restriction is the standing structural friction because it withholds the specific good that the partnership is supposed to supply, while Sikri's caution against enmeshing military planning while remaining heavily dependent on Russian equipment shows that friction runs in both directions. Qualification: the answer must not convert exposure into obligation, because another state's unilateral tariff or sanctions law creates secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India, and it must not treat the tariff measures as settled policy, since they were executive-order-based and reversible within months. Why this earns marks: it explains a mechanism with dated, checkable examples on both the convergence and the friction side, and it names the exact legal character of each instrument.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2019 General Studies Paper II Question 20”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: friction persists inside a deepening relationship because India's place in United States global strategy is instrumental rather than allied, so convergence and coercion can operate at the same time. Named evidence and example: Tharoor's recommendation to view the relationship as a tactical partnership serving both countries' short-term interests together with his caution against hyperbole; his separate record of continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India; the enabling architecture of the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020; the 2016 Major Defence Partner designation and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025; and the tariff sequence in which a twenty-five per cent reciprocal duty took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326, an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329 and was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, with a separate ten per cent Section

301 duty from 24 July 2026 and India's official description of the Russian-oil-linked action as unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025. Analysis: the enabling agreements raise interoperability, logistics and situational awareness without creating an obligation, which is exactly the arrangement a state seeking freedom of action wants, but the same absence of obligation leaves India exposed to unilateral measures that a treaty ally would contest through alliance machinery; technology-access restriction is the standing structural friction because it withholds the specific good that the partnership is supposed to supply, while Sikri's caution against enmeshing military planning while remaining heavily dependent on Russian equipment shows that friction runs in both directions. Qualification: the answer must not convert exposure into obligation, because another state's unilateral tariff or sanctions law creates secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India, and it must not treat the tariff measures as settled policy, since they were executive-order-based and reversible within months. Why this earns marks: it explains a mechanism with dated, checkable examples on both the convergence and the friction side, and it names the exact legal character of each instrument.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2019 General Studies Paper II Question 20 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: friction persists inside a deepening relationship because India's place in United States global strategy is instrumental rather than allied, so convergence and coercion can operate at the same time. Named evidence and example: Tharoor's recommendation to view the relationship as a tactical partnership serving both countries' short-term interests together with his caution against hyperbole; his separate record of continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India; the enabling architecture of the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018 and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020; the 2016 Major Defence Partner designation and the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025; and the tariff sequence in which a twenty-five per cent reciprocal duty took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326, an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329 and was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, with a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty from 24 July 2026 and India's official description of the Russian-oil-linked action as unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025. Analysis: the enabling agreements raise interoperability, logistics and situational awareness without creating an obligation, which is exactly the arrangement a state seeking freedom of action wants, but the same absence of obligation leaves India exposed to unilateral measures that a treaty ally would contest through alliance machinery; technology-access restriction is the standing structural friction because it withholds the specific good that the partnership is supposed to supply, while Sikri's caution against enmeshing military planning while remaining heavily dependent on Russian equipment shows that friction runs in both directions. Qualification: the answer must not convert exposure into obligation, because another state's unilateral tariff or sanctions law creates secondary risk rather than a binding international-law duty on India, and it must not treat the tariff measures as settled policy, since they were executive-order-based and reversible within months. Why this earns marks: it explains a mechanism with dated, checkable examples on both the convergence and the friction side, and it names the exact legal character of each instrument.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 2 - 2019 General Studies Paper II Question 20", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2021 General Studies Paper II Question 10

Demand: The United States facing an existential challenge from China, an Explain demand of 10 marks and 150 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger, where the Core route is recorded as superseding the older Advanced ownership. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

Model solution: Claim: the challenge is best explained as structural and economic rather than merely military, because it operates through concentration of manufacturing and technology capacity, and India's relevance to it is as a diversification partner rather than as a bloc member. Named evidence and example: the Western interest in reducing concentration risk that produced friend-shoring and trusted-supply-chain policy; the initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology announced in May 2022 with its inaugural meeting on 31 January 2023 and second review on 17 June 2024 covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the clean-energy supply-chain commitments of 21 September 2024; the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative launched by Australia, India and Japan in April 2021; and the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 as minilateral vehicles. Analysis: concentration in electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates converts an ordinary commercial dependence into a strategic vulnerability, which is why the response is expressed through technology-cooperation initiatives and plurilateral matching mechanisms rather than through tariffs alone, and why India is approached as an alternative production and technology base; the same logic explains why India accepts the opportunity through specific instruments rather than through a bloc commitment. Qualification: the explanation must not slide into asserting that India replaces China or joins an anti-China alliance, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs is a multi-year undertaking, India's own posture is de-risking rather than decoupling, and minilateral coalitions carry real coordination costs across partners with differing priorities. Why this earns marks: it explains a systemic mechanism with dated instruments, keeps India's position correctly classified, and states the scale limit that most answers omit.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2021 General Studies Paper II Question 10", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: the challenge is best explained as structural and economic rather than merely military, because it operates through concentration of manufacturing and technology capacity, and India's relevance to it is as a diversification partner rather than as a bloc member. Named evidence and example: the Western interest in reducing concentration risk that produced friend-shoring and trusted-supply-chain policy; the initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology announced in May 2022 with its inaugural meeting on 31 January 2023 and second review on 17 June 2024 covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the clean-energy supply-chain commitments of 21 September 2024; the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative launched by Australia, India and Japan in April 2021; and the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 as minilateral vehicles. Analysis: concentration in electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates converts an ordinary commercial dependence into a strategic vulnerability, which is why the response is expressed through technology-cooperation initiatives and plurilateral matching mechanisms rather than through tariffs alone, and why India is approached as an alternative production and technology base; the same logic explains why India accepts the opportunity through specific instruments rather than through a bloc commitment. Qualification: the explanation must not slide into asserting that India replaces China or joins an anti-China alliance, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs is a multi-year undertaking, India's own posture is de-risking rather than decoupling, and minilateral coalitions carry real coordination costs across partners with differing priorities. Why this earns marks: it explains a systemic mechanism with dated instruments, keeps India's position correctly classified, and states the scale limit that most answers omit.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2021 General Studies Paper II Question 10 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency,

causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

2. **Claim and named evidence:** Demand: The United States facing an existential challenge from China, an Explain demand of 10 marks and 150 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2018-2023 Mains routing ledger.

Analysis: Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: the challenge is best explained as structural and economic rather than merely military, because it operates through concentration of manufacturing and technology capacity, and India's relevance to it is as a diversification partner rather than as a bloc member. Named evidence and example: the Western interest in reducing concentration risk that produced friend-shoring and trusted-supply-chain policy; the initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology announced in May 2022 with its inaugural meeting on 31 January 2023 and second review on 17 June 2024 covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the clean-energy supply-chain commitments of 21 September 2024; the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative launched by Australia, India and Japan in April 2021; and the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 as minilateral vehicles. Analysis: concentration in electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates converts an ordinary commercial dependence into a strategic vulnerability, which is why the response is expressed through technology-cooperation initiatives and plurilateral matching mechanisms rather than through tariffs alone, and why India is approached as an alternative production and technology base; the same logic explains why India accepts the opportunity through specific instruments rather than through a bloc commitment. Qualification: the explanation must not slide into asserting that India replaces China or joins an anti-China alliance, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs is a multi-year undertaking, India's own posture is de-risking rather than decoupling, and minilateral coalitions carry real coordination costs across partners with differing priorities. Why this earns marks: it explains a systemic mechanism with dated instruments, keeps India's position correctly classified, and states the scale limit that most answers omit.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 3 - 2021 General Studies Paper II Question 10", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

PYQ DEMAND CARD 4 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 9

Demand: The supplied paper text is reproduced exactly as printed, including its apparent defects: "The West is fostering India as an alternative to reduce dependence on China's supply chain and as a strategically to counter China's political and economic dominance." Explain this statement with examples, an Explain demand of 10 marks and 150 words, exactly as recorded in the audited 2024-2025 Mains routing ledger.

Status: Routed to this owner in the audited 2024-2025 Mains routing ledger and reproduced in the Basic owner with its printed defects retained rather than silently corrected. No official answer key exists for a Mains demand and none is claimed.

Model solution: Claim: the statement is accurate as a description of Western intent but must be qualified twice, because fostering means diversification rather than replacement and because the fostering itself proved conditional and reversible. Named evidence and example: the initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology and its review of 17 June 2024 covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments of 21 September 2024; TRUST and COMPACT announced on 13 February 2025 with Mission 500 and the launch of bilateral trade-agreement negotiations; the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership signed on 31 October 2025; and, as counter-evidence, the

twenty-five per cent reciprocal duty effective 7 August 2025, the additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty effective 27 August 2025 and removed from 7 February 2026, and the separate ten per cent Section 301 duty from 24 July 2026. Analysis: each named instrument is a real, dated expression of Western diversification interest and together they show technology, energy and defence-industrial channels opening at once, which is what fostering means in practice; yet the same partner applied coercive trade measures during the same window, so the fostering is transactional and conditional, and India's simultaneous continuation of the China dialogue through the twenty-fourth Special Representatives round of 19 August 2025 and of the Russia track through the twenty-third Annual Summit of 4 and 5 December 2025 demonstrates that India accepts the opportunity without adopting an anti-China alliance posture. Qualification: the answer must reject the replacement reading, since China remains a major trading partner even as alternative capacity develops elsewhere, must not describe any of the named instruments as a treaty or alliance, and must treat the tariff measures as dated executive actions rather than a standing rate. Why this earns marks: it explains the statement with concrete dated examples, supplies the strongest available counter-evidence instead of accepting the premise uncritically, and closes on the strategic-autonomy point that the three tracks ran simultaneously.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “PYQ DEMAND CARD 4 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 9”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Claim: the statement is accurate as a description of Western intent but must be qualified twice, because fostering means diversification rather than replacement and because the fostering itself proved conditional and reversible. Named evidence and example: the initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology and its review of 17 June 2024 covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments of 21 September 2024; TRUST and COMPACT announced on 13 February 2025 with Mission 500 and the launch of bilateral trade-agreement negotiations; the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership signed on 31 October 2025; and, as counter-evidence, the twenty-five per cent reciprocal duty effective 7 August 2025, the additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty effective 27 August 2025 and removed from 7 February 2026, and the separate ten per cent Section 301 duty from 24 July 2026. Analysis: each named instrument is a real, dated expression of Western diversification interest and together they show technology, energy and defence-industrial channels opening at once, which is what fostering means in practice; yet the same partner applied coercive trade measures during the same window, so the fostering is transactional and conditional, and India's simultaneous continuation of the China dialogue through the twenty-fourth Special Representatives round of 19 August 2025 and of the Russia track through the twenty-third Annual Summit of 4 and 5 December 2025 demonstrates that India accepts the opportunity without adopting an anti-China alliance posture. Qualification: the answer must reject the replacement reading, since China remains a major trading partner even as alternative capacity develops elsewhere, must not describe any of the named instruments as a treaty or alliance, and must treat the tariff measures as dated executive actions rather than a standing rate. Why this earns marks: it explains the statement with concrete dated examples, supplies the strongest available counter-evidence instead of accepting the premise uncritically, and closes on the strategic-autonomy point that the three tracks ran simultaneously.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** PYQ DEMAND CARD 4 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 9 **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Claim: the statement is accurate as a description of Western intent but must be qualified twice, because fostering means diversification rather than replacement and because the fostering itself proved conditional

and reversible. Named evidence and example: the initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology and its review of 17 June 2024 covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments of 21 September 2024; TRUST and COMPACT announced on 13 February 2025 with Mission 500 and the launch of bilateral trade-agreement negotiations; the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership signed on 31 October 2025; and, as counter-evidence, the twenty-five per cent reciprocal duty effective 7 August 2025, the additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty effective 27 August 2025 and removed from 7 February 2026, and the separate ten per cent Section 301 duty from 24 July 2026. Analysis: each named instrument is a real, dated expression of Western diversification interest and together they show technology, energy and defence-industrial channels opening at once, which is what fostering means in practice; yet the same partner applied coercive trade measures during the same window, so the fostering is transactional and conditional, and India's simultaneous continuation of the China dialogue through the twenty-fourth Special Representatives round of 19 August 2025 and of the Russia track through the twenty-third Annual Summit of 4 and 5 December 2025 demonstrates that India accepts the opportunity without adopting an anti-China alliance posture. Qualification: the answer must reject the replacement reading, since China remains a major trading partner even as alternative capacity develops elsewhere, must not describe any of the named instruments as a treaty or alliance, and must treat the tariff measures as dated executive actions rather than a standing rate. Why this earns marks: it explains the statement with concrete dated examples, supplies the strongest available counter-evidence instead of accepting the premise uncritically, and closes on the strategic-autonomy point that the three tracks ran simultaneously.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

How to improve this answer: For "PYQ DEMAND CARD 4 - 2024 General Studies Paper II Question 9", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 1 - 10 MARKS

Question: Explain why high trade volume between India and China coexists with enduring strategic mistrust. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: Trade volume and strategic trust are separate variables because the relationship is political and strategic in origin and rests on an unresolved boundary dispute, so the answer must separate the two dimensions, add the raw-material-for-manufactured-goods asymmetry as a compounding grievance, and qualify any ranking claim as requiring current official trade data.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement.
- Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track.
- De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other

manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner.

- On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement.

Qualified conclusion: Trade volume and strategic trust are separate variables because the relationship is political and strategic in origin and rests on an unresolved boundary dispute, so the answer must separate the two dimensions, add the raw-material-for-manufactured-goods asymmetry as a compounding grievance, and qualify any ranking claim as requiring current official trade data.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on “Explain why high trade volume between India and China coexists with enduring strategic...”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Trade volume and strategic trust are separate variables because the relationship is political and strategic in origin and rests on an unresolved boundary dispute, so the answer must separate the two dimensions, add the raw-material-for-manufactured-goods asymmetry as a compounding grievance, and qualify any ranking claim as requiring current official trade data.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate

substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Trade volume and strategic trust are separate variables because the relationship is political and strategic in origin and rests on an unresolved boundary dispute, so the answer must separate the two dimensions, add the raw-material-for-manufactured-goods asymmetry as a compounding grievance, and qualify any ranking claim as requiring current official trade data.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Explain why high trade volume between India and China coexists with enduring strategic...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 2 - 10 MARKS

Question: Comment on the proposition that India's engagement with the United States is best described as a tactical partnership rather than an alliance. Answer in about 150 words.

Model thesis: The tactical-partnership framing is more accurate because every instrument in the relationship is enabling or framework in character and none creates a collective-defence obligation, so the answer must name the enabling agreements and the ten-year framework with their dates and stop short of alliance language, while conceding the unresolved technology-access friction.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in

this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India.

- Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier.
- The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2016 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment.
- The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery.

Qualified conclusion: The tactical-partnership framing is more accurate because every instrument in the relationship is enabling or framework in character and none creates a collective-defence obligation, so the answer must name the enabling agreements and the ten-year framework with their dates and stop short of alliance language, while conceding the unresolved technology-access friction.

Demand decoding: The directive **comment** requires a direct position on “Comment on the proposition that India’s engagement with the United States is best described...”, every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The tactical-partnership framing is more accurate because every instrument in the relationship is enabling or framework in character and none creates a collective-defence obligation, so the answer must name the enabling agreements and the ten-year framework with their dates and stop short of alliance language, while conceding the unresolved technology-access friction.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries’ short-term interests and cautions against hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate,

announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence.

Qualification: State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The tactical-partnership framing is more accurate because every instrument in the relationship is enabling or framework in character and none creates a collective-defence obligation, so the answer must name the enabling agreements and the ten-year framework with their dates and stop short of alliance language, while conceding the unresolved technology-access friction.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 10 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Comment on the proposition that India's engagement with the United States is best described...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 3 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine the concrete instruments through which the West's supply-chain diversification interest in India has been expressed, and state what they do not establish. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: The instruments are real, dated and cumulative but each stops at a specific evidentiary level, so the examination must run from the initiative of May 2022 through the review of 17 June 2024, the clean-energy commitments of 21 September 2024 and the branding of 13 February 2025, and close by refusing the replacement narrative in favour of diversification of dependence.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United

States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale.

- The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations.
- India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available.
- Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession.

Qualified conclusion: The instruments are real, dated and cumulative but each stops at a specific evidentiary level, so the examination must run from the initiative of May 2022 through the review of 17 June 2024, the clean-energy commitments of 21 September 2024 and the branding of 13 February 2025, and close by refusing the replacement narrative in favour of diversification of dependence.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine the concrete instruments through which the West's supply-chain diversification...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The instruments are real, dated and cumulative but each stops at a specific evidentiary level, so the examination must run from the initiative of May 2022 through the review of 17 June 2024, the clean-energy commitments of 21 September 2024 and the branding of 13 February 2025, and close by refusing the replacement narrative in favour of diversification of dependence.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a

second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The instruments are real, dated and cumulative but each stops at a specific evidentiary level, so the examination must run from the initiative of May 2022 through the review of 17 June 2024, the clean-energy commitments of 21 September 2024 and the branding of 13 February 2025, and close by refusing the replacement narrative in favour of diversification of dependence.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Examine the concrete instruments through which the West's supply-chain diversification...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 4 - 15 MARKS

Question: Examine India's simultaneous engagement with the United States, China and Russia during 2024 to 2026 as a test of hedging capacity. Answer in about 250 words.

Model thesis: Simultaneity is the empirical test of hedging, so the examination must date the three tracks within a single window, price the tariff cycle as a real but reversible third-party cost, distinguish exposure from obligation, and qualify the verdict with the installed-base dependence that the hedge has not yet removed.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority.
- On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement.
- An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy.
- Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India.

Qualified conclusion: Simultaneity is the empirical test of hedging, so the examination must date the three tracks within a single window, price the tariff cycle as a real but reversible third-party cost, distinguish exposure from obligation, and qualify the verdict with the installed-base dependence that the hedge has not yet removed.

Demand decoding: The directive **examine** requires a direct position on "Examine India's simultaneous engagement with the United States, China and Russia during 2024...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Simultaneity is the empirical test of hedging, so the examination must date the three tracks within a single window, price the tariff cycle as a real but reversible third-party cost, distinguish exposure from obligation, and qualify the verdict with the installed-base dependence that the hedge has not yet removed.

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 4. Claim and named evidence:** Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Simultaneity is the empirical test of hedging, so the examination must date the three tracks within a single window, price the tariff cycle as a real but reversible third-party cost, distinguish exposure from obligation, and qualify the verdict with the installed-base dependence that the hedge has not yet removed.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 15 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Examine India's simultaneous engagement with the United States, China and Russia during 2024...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 5 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess whether India's supply-chain resilience agenda can reduce dependence without decoupling from China. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: Reduction without decoupling is feasible only at multi-year scale and only where diversification partners actually deliver capacity, so the assessment must define de-risking against decoupling, evaluate the Japan and European Union pillars at their exact evidentiary levels, name the technology-access and coordination limits, and close with a graded verdict rather than a target.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner.
- The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production.
- The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains.
- Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while

Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

Qualified conclusion: Reduction without decoupling is feasible only at multi-year scale and only where diversification partners actually deliver capacity, so the assessment must define de-risking against decoupling, evaluate the Japan and European Union pillars at their exact evidentiary levels, name the technology-access and coordination limits, and close with a graded verdict rather than a target.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess whether India's supply-chain resilience agenda can reduce dependence without...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: Reduction without decoupling is feasible only at multi-year scale and only where diversification partners actually deliver capacity, so the assessment must define de-risking against decoupling, evaluate the Japan and European Union pillars at their exact evidentiary levels, name the technology-access and coordination limits, and close with a graded verdict rather than a target.

Analytical body:

- 1. Claim and named evidence:** De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 2. Claim and named evidence:** The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
- 3. Claim and named evidence:** The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap in its clearest form, because a concluded

negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

4. **Claim and named evidence:** Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: Reduction without decoupling is feasible only at multi-year scale and only where diversification partners actually deliver capacity, so the assessment must define de-risking against decoupling, evaluate the Japan and European Union pillars at their exact evidentiary levels, name the technology-access and coordination limits, and close with a graded verdict rather than a target.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

How to improve this answer: For "Assess whether India's supply-chain resilience agenda can reduce dependence without...", replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

ORIGINAL MAINS 6 - 20 MARKS

Question: Assess India's three-track major-power engagement as a single strategic design rather than three unrelated bilateral policies. Answer in about 300 words.

Model thesis: The three tracks form one design because each is routed to a different interest and none is allowed to become exclusive, so the assessment must state the structural difference between the China, United States and Russia relationships, evidence each with dated instruments at their exact levels, acknowledge the autonomy-dependence trade-off if any single track deepens disproportionately, and relink the conclusion to strategic autonomy.

Claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification:

- This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12.
- In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement.
- Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks.
- An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy.

Qualified conclusion: The three tracks form one design because each is routed to a different interest and none is allowed to become exclusive, so the assessment must state the structural difference between the China, United States and Russia relationships, evidence each with dated instruments at their exact levels, acknowledge the autonomy-dependence trade-off if any single track deepens disproportionately, and relink the conclusion to strategic autonomy.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on "Assess India's three-track major-power engagement as a single strategic design rather than...", every clause, bilateral/regional/systemic mapping, interests and constraints, objective-instrument-implementation-outcome separation, named Indian evidence, trade-offs, alternatives, implementation risks and a qualified conclusion.

Detailed examiner-grade model answer:

Introduction and thesis: The three tracks form one design because each is routed to a different interest and none is allowed to become exclusive, so the assessment must state the structural difference between the China, United States and Russia relationships, evidence each with dated instruments at their exact levels, acknowledge the autonomy-dependence trade-off if any single track deepens disproportionately, and relink the conclusion to strategic autonomy.

Analytical body:

1. **Claim and named evidence:** This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and

partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

2. **Claim and named evidence:** In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy. **Analysis:** Connect Indian and partner interests -> chosen diplomatic, security, economic or institutional instrument -> implementation mechanism -> bilateral, regional and systemic consequence. **Qualification:** State membership and mandate, announced/signed/ratified/operative/completed status, official source and date, partner agency, causal limit, trade-off, alternative or residual implementation risk.

Counter-position / limit: A doctrine label, summit declaration, signed document, project announcement, military exercise, trade change or diplomatic statement cannot alone establish binding obligation, operational delivery or strategic outcome; test legal character, implementation, partner response, alternatives and evidence status.

Qualified conclusion: The three tracks form one design because each is routed to a different interest and none is allowed to become exclusive, so the assessment must state the structural difference between the China, United States and Russia relationships, evidence each with dated instruments at their exact levels, acknowledge the autonomy-dependence trade-off if any single track deepens disproportionately, and relink the conclusion to strategic autonomy.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For 20 marks, spend one-sixth of the time decoding the directive and drawing level -> interest -> instrument -> implementation -> outcome -> alternative; state a thesis; write four to seven claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification points; reserve the final minute for source, date, membership, operative status, partner agency, causation, escalation and residual risk.

Why this earns marks: The answer obeys the directive, explains strategy and implementation rather than listing visits or groupings, uses named India-centric evidence and preserves institutional, status, level, causal and geopolitical distinctions.

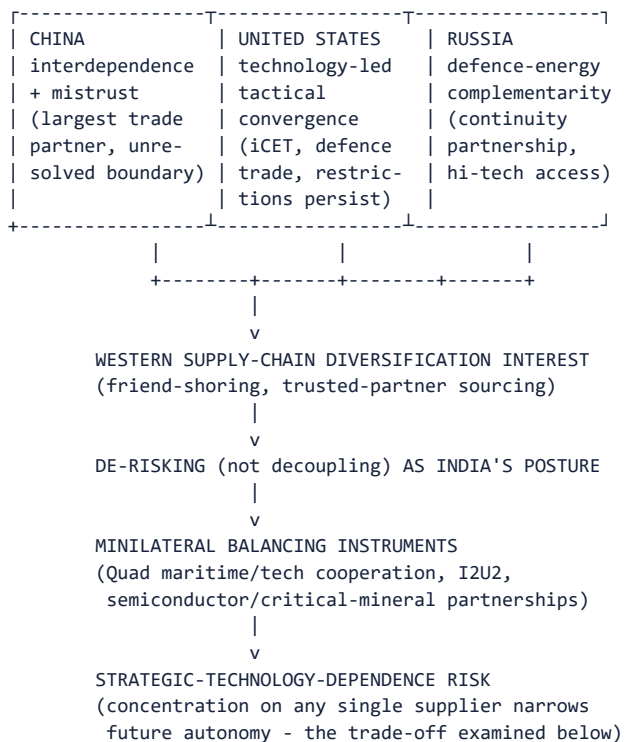
How to improve this answer: For “Assess India's three-track major-power engagement as a single strategic design rather than...”, replace the weakest event-list point with one named actor, interest, instrument, implementation bottleneck, measurable outcome, alternative and source-date-status qualification.

OPTIONAL ADVANCED DEPTH - NOT REQUIRED FOR A CORE ANSWER

Subject: International Relations | **Tier:** Advanced | **GS Paper:** GS-II. **Core area:** Competition/cooperation with major powers; de-risking versus decoupling; strategic-technology dependence; minilateral balancing. **Grounded in:** Rajiv Sikri, *Challenges and Strategy: Rethinking India's Foreign Policy*; Shashi Tharoor, *Pax Indica*; MEA/White House iCET documentation; 00_Master-Framework.md Sections 4-7. **FACT:** = source-grounded | **ANALYSIS:** = inference/analysis | **CURRENT:** = current anchor. *Companion:* basic/03_India-China-Major-Powers-and-Resilient-Supply-Chains.md.

1. Architecture

THREE STRUCTURALLY DIFFERENT MAJOR-POWER TIES



Analytical claim: ANALYSIS: The West's interest in India as a supply-chain alternative to China is real and instrumentally useful to India, but it does not convert India into an anti-China bloc member; India simultaneously sustains significant China trade, deepens US technology ties, and preserves Russian defence-energy complementarity - a three-track hedge, not a binary choice.

2. Concepts and distinctions

Concept	Precise meaning
FACT: Trade interdependence vs. strategic trust (China)	FACT: Sikri's book-period assessment separates the two explicitly: China as "India's largest trading partner" coexists with "some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion" rooted in "an unresolved boundary dispute" - high trade volume is not evidence of political trust. Use current official trade data for any present-day ranking.
ANALYSIS: De-risking vs. decoupling	De-risking reduces overconcentration in a single supplier while sustaining engagement (India's actual posture toward China); decoupling implies severing engagement altogether - conflating the two overstates India's China policy.
FACT: Tactical partnership vs. alliance (US)	FACT: Tharoor recommends viewing the India-US relationship "as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests," explicitly cautioning against "hyperbole" that would frame it as an alliance.
ANALYSIS: Technology-access asymmetry	FACT: Tharoor notes "continuing restrictions on the sale of US high technology to India" persist despite the political warmth - a genuine friction point, not a solved problem, that qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence.
FACT: Defence-energy complementarity (Russia)	FACT: Sikri: the relationship rests on India being "energy-deficient" and Russia "energy-surplus," reinforced by Russia's unique position as supplier of high-technology defence equipment (including nuclear-powered submarines) "unavailable from elsewhere."
ANALYSIS: Minilateral balancing	Using small, issue-specific coalitions (Quad, I2U2) to advance supply-chain and technology cooperation with multiple partners simultaneously, without a formal alliance commitment to any one - distinct from bilateral deepening with a single power.

3. Detailed causal chain: from mistrust/complementarity to resilient supply chains

- China: economic engagement outpaces strategic trust.** FACT: In Sikri's book-period assessment, "China is today India's largest trading partner," yet the relationship "is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute" - trade growth alone does not resolve the underlying security competition.
- Trade-pattern asymmetry compounds mistrust.** FACT: Sikri notes India's concern "over its trade deficit" and the pattern "India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities, and China mostly manufactured products," with Chinese firms "suspected of dumping" given China's "non-market economy with opaque pricing" - an economic grievance layered onto strategic mistrust.
- The West identifies India as a diversification partner.** Given China's dominant manufacturing role, Western economies with concentration risk look to India (among others) as an alternative production and technology-cooperation base.
- **India accepts the opportunity through a specific instrument (iCET, 17 June 2024. rather than a bloc commitment**, consistent with the strategic-autonomy principle (topic 01) of engaging each interest through the platform best suited to it.**
- Simultaneously, India sustains the Russia defence-energy track** - Sikri's complementarity logic (energy-deficient/energy-surplus) continues to operate independently of the US-technology track, since the two serve different interests (energy/defence-equipment access versus critical/emerging-technology access).
- US-supplied technology restrictions persist as friction** (Tharoor),

meaning the "convergence" narrative should not be overstated as unconditional access - India continues to diversify rather than depend on any single supplier.

7. **Trade-off materialises if any one track deepens too far:** over-reliance on

Russian defence equipment, or on US technology inputs, both carry the autonomy-dependence trade-off identified in 00_Master - Framework .md Section 4 and the advanced file for topic 01.

8. **Outcome: a three-track hedge**, not a binary China-versus-West alignment - the correct analytical frame for any Mains answer on this topic.

4. Institutional and reform architecture

- FACT: ****iCET** (announced May 2022; inaugural NSA-level meeting 31 January 2023; second NSA-level review 17 June 2024):** the two National Security Advisers reviewed India-US cooperation on semiconductors, AI, space and defence-industrial collaboration - a cooperation initiative, not a treaty or framework agreement.

- CURRENT: **India-US clean-energy supply-chain commitments (21 September 2024):** extends the resilience agenda from technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs.

- CURRENT: **TRUST and COMPACT (13 February 2025):** the current India-US technology and defence-commerce branding, announced with **Mission 500** and the launch of bilateral trade-agreement negotiations. ANALYSIS: The official statement does not say TRUST terminated or superseded iCET - an important precision point, since treating a rebrand as a legal succession misstates the architecture.

- CURRENT: ****Framework for the US-India Major Defense Partnership (Kuala Lumpur, 31 October 2025):**** a ten-year defence framework. ANALYSIS: A framework is not a mutual-defence treaty; Tharoor's "tactical partnership" caution still applies.

- CURRENT: **The 2025-26 US tariff cycle as an architecture stress test:** a 25% India-specific reciprocal duty (effective 7 August 2025) and an additional 25% Russian-oil-linked duty (effective 27 August 2025) were imposed, the latter removed from 7 February 2026 and IEEPA additional duties ended that month, with a separate 10% Section 301 duty from 24 July 2026. ANALYSIS: This is the clearest available evidence that "friend-shoring" partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner - a decisive qualification to any simple "the West is fostering India" reading (2024 Q9).

- CURRENT: **India-Russia continuity architecture:** the 23rd Annual Summit (New Delhi, 4-5 December 2025) during President Putin's state visit produced the joint statement "Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust & Mutual Respect" and a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030. ANALYSIS: Treat S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes as separately unverified without an official figure.

- CURRENT: **India-China border and dialogue architecture:** the patrolling arrangement announced 21 October 2024 (Depsang and Demchok); the 23rd Special Representatives round (Beijing, 18 December 2024) and 24th round (New Delhi, 19 August 2025), which agreed an Expert Group on "early harvest" boundary delimitation, a WMCC working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors, and provided for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La; the Modi-Xi meeting at Tianjin on 31 August 2025; and the 35th WMCC (Beijing, 27 May 2026), which prepared for the next SR meeting. ANALYSIS: A process architecture, not a settlement.

- ANALYSIS: **Quad and I2U2 as minilateral supply-chain vehicles:** these non-treaty coalitions provide additional, non-exclusive channels for diversification cooperation, distinct from the bilateral track (full institutional profile reserved for topic 10).

5. Indian applications and boundary cases

- FACT: **Direct PYQ boundary case (2024 Q9):** the supplied paper text reads verbatim, "the West is fostering India... as a strategically to counter China's political and economic dominance"; its apparent defects should be acknowledged rather than silently repaired. The underlying proposition must be qualified in a strong answer: India accepts diversification opportunities without adopting an anti-China alliance posture;

conflating the two would misstate India's actual position.

- ANALYSIS: ****Boundary case - trade deficit with China as economic grievance layered on strategic mistrust:**** Sikri's point about raw-material-for-manufactured- goods trade patterns shows that even the "cooperative" economic relationship carries structural asymmetry, reinforcing (not offsetting) the strategic distrust.

- ANALYSIS: **Boundary case - Russia-US simultaneous engagement:** the continued functioning of both tracks (Russian defence-energy complementarity, US technology convergence) without either being sacrificed is the central empirical test of India's hedging capacity, and increasingly sensitive as US-Russia tensions evolve.

- ANALYSIS: **Boundary case - unresolved technology-access asymmetry with the US:** Tharoor's point about continuing export-control restrictions shows that even the most rapidly deepening major-power partnership retains real friction - a corrective against overly optimistic "strategic convergence" narratives.

6. Limitations and trade-offs

- ANALYSIS: **De-risking has limits given China's manufacturing scale:** full diversification away from China-linked inputs (electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients, and other manufactured intermediates) is a multi-year undertaking, not an immediate substitution - Economy owns the precise trade-data mechanics of this transition.

- ANALYSIS: **US technology-transfer friction persists:** Tharoor's export-control point means India cannot assume unconditional US technology access even under iCET; negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing.

- ANALYSIS: **Russia-defence dependence risk:** Sikri's own caution against "enmesh[ing]" military planning with the US while remaining "heavily dependent on Russian military equipment" without reciprocal US technology- sharing illustrates a genuine strategic bind, not a costless hedge. The advanced file for topic 01 develops this trade-off further.

- ANALYSIS: **Minilateral coalitions carry coordination costs:** Quad/I2U2-style cooperation requires aligning multiple partners' differing priorities, which can slow delivery relative to a purely bilateral arrangement.

- ANALYSIS: **Risk of overstated "replacement" narrative:** treating India as "replacing" China in global supply chains (rather than diversifying dependence) is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale, and is flagged explicitly as a trap in the basic file.

7. Must-Know Facts for Advanced Prelims

- FACT: Sikri documents a specific 2007-era Indian trade deficit with China "over \$10 billion," alongside the raw-material-for-manufactured-goods trade pattern - cite as historical/period evidence of the underlying economic grievance, not a current figure.

- FACT: Tharoor explicitly recommends framing India-US relations as a "tactical partnership," not an alliance, cautioning against "hyperbole."

- FACT: Sikri identifies nuclear-powered submarines as an example of high-technology defence equipment India can source only from Russia.

- CURRENT: The dated 2024-2026 anchors for this topic are: iCET review (17 June 2024); clean-energy supply-chain commitments (21 September 2024); the India-China patrolling arrangement (21 October 2024); TRUST and COMPACT (13 February 2025); the 24th Special Representatives round (19 August 2025); the Modi-Xi meeting at Tianjin (31 August 2025); the ten-year US-India Major Defense Partnership framework (31 October 2025); and the 23rd India-Russia Annual Summit (4-5 December 2025).

- CURRENT: The US tariff sequence - 25% reciprocal duty from 7 August 2025, an additional 25% Russian-oil-linked duty from 27 August 2025, its removal from 7 February 2026 and a separate 10% Section 301 duty from 24 July 2026 - is the dated counter-evidence to a one-directional "fostering" narrative.

8. Advanced Prelims traps

- WRONG: De-risking and decoupling are interchangeable terms for the same policy. ->

De-risking reduces overconcentration while sustaining engagement; decoupling implies full disengagement - India's China policy is the former.

- WRONG: iCET is a defence-alliance treaty. -> It is a critical-and-emerging-technology cooperation framework, not a mutual-defence treaty.

- WRONG: India's growing US technology ties have resolved all prior technology-transfer restrictions. -> Tharoor's caution about continuing export restrictions remains a valid, unresolved friction point.

- WRONG: India's trade deficit with China is a recent development. -> Sikri documents this pattern from an earlier period; the underlying structural asymmetry (raw materials for manufactured goods) long predates any current figure.

9. CURRENT: Current-anchor note

- CURRENT: The strongest current framing for this topic is the **three-track simultaneity of 2025**: TRUST/COMPACT with the US (13 February 2025), the 24th Special Representatives round with China (19 August 2025) and the 23rd Annual Summit with Russia (4-5 December 2025) - all within ten months, and all while a US Russian-oil-linked tariff was in force against India. ANALYSIS: Any newer summit outcome or agreement claim requires independent, dated verification before being treated as FACT:.

10. PYQ-based analytical application

- FACT: **2024 Q9 (direct; local paper text reproduced verbatim)**: "The West is fostering India as an alternative to reduce dependence on China's supply chain and as a strategically to counter China's political and economic dominance." Explain this statement with examples.* An advanced-level answer should:

1. Separate the economic (diversification opportunity) and strategic (mistrust of China) dimensions explicitly.
2. Cite iCET (17 June 2024 review), the clean-energy supply-chain commitments (21 September 2024) and TRUST/COMPACT (13 February 2025) as concrete evidence.
3. Qualify the "counter China's dominance" framing - India pursues diversification, not an anti-China alliance, and sustains simultaneous China engagement (the 24th SR round, 19 August 2025) and Russia defence-energy ties (23rd Annual Summit, 4-5 December 2025).
4. Flag the autonomy-dependence trade-off if the US-technology track deepens without reciprocal technology-sharing, and cite the 2025-26 US tariff cycle as evidence that "fostering" is conditional and reversible.

11. Mains-ready framework

Central thesis: India's major-power engagement is a three-track hedge - economic interdependence with strategic mistrust toward China, technology-led tactical (not alliance) convergence with the US, and continuity-based defence-energy complementarity with Russia - channelled into concrete, dated supply-chain-resilience instruments without collapsing into a binary China-versus-West alignment.

1. **Separate trade interdependence from strategic trust** for China.
2. **Use "tactical partnership," not alliance**, for the US relationship.
3. **Use "complementarity," not one-sided dependence**, for Russia, while noting the real dependence-risk caveat.
4. **Cite the dated anchors** - iCET/TRUST, the patrolling arrangement and SR rounds, and the India-Russia Annual Summit - as concrete evidence of Western diversification interest and of simultaneous three-track engagement.
5. **Reject the "replacement" narrative** in favour of "diversification of

dependence."

6. **Acknowledge the autonomy-dependence trade-off** if any single track deepens disproportionately.

7. **Close by relinking to strategic autonomy** (topic 01) as the organising principle across all three tracks.

12. Probable questions

- FACT: **Mains (10 marks, direct 2024 PYQ; local text verbatim):** "The West is fostering India as an alternative to reduce dependence on China's supply chain and as a strategically to counter China's political and economic dominance." Explain this statement with examples.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (15 marks):** "India's China policy is de-risking, not decoupling." Critically examine with reference to trade interdependence and strategic mistrust.
- ANALYSIS: **Mains (15 marks):** Assess whether India's simultaneous deepening of technology ties with the US and defence-energy ties with Russia is a sustainable long-term hedge.

13. Study links

- FACT: Foundation companion:
basic/03_India-China-Major-Powers-and-Resilient-Supply-Chains.md.
- FACT: Economy/basic/20_Foreign-Trade-WTO-FTAs-and-Protectionism.md - trade and tariff mechanics.
- FACT: 00_Master-Framework.md Section 4 - the strategic-autonomy and autonomy-dependence trade-off framework.
- ANALYSIS: **Cross-links within this folder:** topic 01 (advanced) for the autonomy-dependence trade-off in full detail; topic 10 for Quad/I2U2 institutional profiles; topic 11 for globalisation/de-risking as a systemic trend; topic 12 for China's role in UN reform debates.

Historical PYQ Integration (2018-2023)

Status: Question-level PYQ demand is integrated into this owner. **Provenance:** Audited local official-paper routing ledgers: _PYQ-ROUTING-MAINS-GS1-GS2-ESSAY-2018-2023.md.

- **Years represented:** 2019, 2021
- **Paper(s):** GS-II
- **Routed question demands:** 3

Year	Paper	Q	PYQ demand (neutral rendering)	Directive / format	Source status	Owner requirement
2019	GS-II	9	India-Japan contemporary global and strategic partnership	Comment · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic; word limit taken from the instruction block	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2019	GS-II	20	Friction in India-US ties and India's place in US global strategy	Explain with suitable examples · 15 marks · 250 words	Routed to owning topic; word limit taken from the instruction block	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.
2021	GS-II	10	The USA facing an existential challenge from China	Explain · 10 marks · 150 words	Routed to owning topic	Prepare context, core dimensions, evidence/examples, counterpoint and a concise conclusion.

What this owner must now support

- India-Japan contemporary global and strategic partnership
- Friction in India-US ties and India's place in US global strategy
- The USA facing an existential challenge from China

The table integrates the examinable demand and paper metadata. It does not turn an unkeyed objective question into a solved answer, and it does not claim that lexical presence alone proves full conceptual sufficiency.

CONSOLIDATED REGISTER NOTES

India, China, Major Powers and Resilient Supply Chains: RAPID ACTOR, INSTRUMENT AND DATED-ANCHOR MAP

1. **What this owner holds and how its boundaries are routed:** This topic owns India's relationships with the United States, China, Russia, the European Union and Japan together with the supply-chain resilience and critical-and-emerging-technology agenda, and its distinctive feature is that it carries the heaviest verified Mains load in the folder, with four General Studies Paper II demands routed to it from 2019, 2021 and 2024 alongside two objective demands from 2019 and 2026; the tariff schedules, balance of payments and trade-deficit mechanics belong to the Economy owner, the institutional profiles of the Quad and I2U2 belong to topic 10, globalisation and de-risking as a systemic trend belong to topic 11, and China's role in Security Council reform belongs to topic 12.
2. **The India-China economic-strategic paradox:** In Sikri's book-period assessment China is India's largest trading partner although the economic relationship is not without its problems, while at the same time India's security concerns and the competition for influence in Asia will ensure some degree of enduring mistrust and suspicion, because the relationship is essentially a political and strategic one arising out of the fact that India and China are neighbours with an unresolved boundary dispute; the examinable discipline is twofold, namely that trade volume is never evidence of strategic trust, and that any present-day ranking claim requires current official trade data rather than a book-period statement.
3. **Trade-pattern asymmetry as an economic grievance layered on strategic mistrust:** Sikri records India's concern over its trade deficit and the pattern of India exporting mostly raw materials and commodities while China exports mostly manufactured products, with Chinese firms suspected of dumping given China's non-market economy with opaque pricing, and he documents a specific trade deficit of over ten billion dollars from the 2007 era; the owners require that figure to be cited as historical period evidence of the underlying grievance rather than as a current number, and the analytical point is that the structural asymmetry reinforces rather than offsets strategic distrust, so the cooperative economic track does not soften the security track.
4. **De-risking against decoupling:** De-risking reduces overconcentration risk in a single supplier or partner while retaining engagement, whereas decoupling implies full disengagement, and the owners record India's posture toward China consistently as de-risking and never as decoupling; the boundary that makes the distinction real is scale, because full diversification away from China-linked inputs such as electronics, active pharmaceutical ingredients and other manufactured intermediates is a multi-year undertaking rather than an immediate substitution, and the precise trade-data mechanics of that transition belong to the Economy owner.
5. **Friend-shoring and trusted supply chains as the Western policy logic:** Friend-shoring means relocating or diversifying critical supply chains toward geopolitically aligned or trusted partners, which is distinct from simple offshoring based on cost alone, and it is the policy logic behind India-United States and India-European Union technology cooperation, with critical minerals such as rare earths, lithium and cobalt and semiconductor fabrication and packaging capacity treated as strategic-supply-chain priorities; the correction the owners insist upon is that Western diversification interest makes India an alternative production and technology-cooperation base rather than a replacement for China, and treating it as replacement is analytically and empirically incorrect at current scale.
6. **The United States track as technology-led tactical convergence:** Tharoor notes that the United States remains a leading arms supplier to India and Sikri observes that after decades of mutual suspicion and wariness India and the United States are moving toward closer alignment, yet Tharoor expressly recommends viewing the relationship as a tactical partnership that serves both countries' short-term interests and cautions against

hyperbole that would frame it as an alliance; the vocabulary rule that follows is that an answer should use tactical partnership rather than alliance, because the enabling instruments in this relationship carry no collective-defence obligation on India.

7. **Technology-access asymmetry as unresolved friction:** Tharoor flags continuing restrictions on the sale of United States high technology to India as friction that persists despite the political warmth, and the owners treat this as a genuine unresolved problem rather than a solved one, which qualifies any claim of full strategic convergence; the operational consequence is that India cannot assume unconditional technology access even under a named cooperation initiative, so negotiation over specific technology categories remains ongoing and diversification remains the rational response rather than dependence on any single supplier.
8. **The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology and its exact status:** The initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology, abbreviated iCET, was announced in May 2022, held its inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting on 31 January 2023 and a second National Security Adviser-level review on 17 June 2024, covering semiconductors, artificial intelligence, space and defence-industrial cooperation; the owners fix its evidentiary level precisely as a cooperation initiative and not a treaty or framework agreement, and they warn that treating it as a defence-alliance treaty misstates both its legal character and India's obligations.
9. **Clean-energy supply-chain commitments of September 2024:** India-United States clean-energy supply-chain commitments were announced on 21 September 2024, extending the resilience agenda from critical and emerging technology into clean-energy manufacturing inputs and announced alongside the broader technology partnership; the owners treat this as one of the concrete dated examples of Western diversification interest that a 2024-style demand expects a candidate to cite, and its evidentiary level is a bilateral commitment announcement rather than a delivered manufacturing outcome, so the claim must stop at commitment unless a separate delivery date is available.
10. **TRUST, COMPACT and Mission 500 of February 2025:** Two India-United States initiatives were announced in the same joint leaders' statement of 13 February 2025, namely TRUST, standing for Transforming the Relationship Utilizing Strategic Technology, for critical-technology cooperation, and COMPACT, standing for Catalyzing Opportunities for Military Partnership, Accelerated Commerce and Technology, announced together with Mission 500, a stated goal of expanding bilateral trade, and with the launch of negotiations toward a bilateral trade agreement; the owners record the decisive precision that the official text does not state that TRUST terminated or superseded iCET, so it must be treated as successor or parallel branding and never as a documented legal succession.
11. **The ten-year defence framework of October 2025 and its non-treaty character:** The Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership was signed at Kuala Lumpur on 31 October 2025 as a ten-year defence framework, and the owners state expressly that a framework is not a mutual-defence treaty and that India carries no collective-defence obligation to the United States; the same discipline extends backwards through the relationship, because the United States designated India a Major Defence Partner in 2016 and that designation likewise conferred a partnership status rather than an alliance commitment.
12. **The enabling-agreement architecture and what it does not create:** The India-United States enabling agreements are the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement of 2016, which enables reciprocal logistics support, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement of 2018, which enables secure communications, and the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement of 2020, which enables exchange of geospatial information, and together they improve interoperability, logistics and situational awareness; the owners attach the limitation directly, namely that they are enabling agreements and not a collective-defence alliance or an automatic basing right, while export controls, commercial negotiation and policy volatility continue to condition actual delivery.
13. **Russia as defence-energy complementarity rather than one-sided dependence:** Sikri grounds the India-Russia relationship in the observation that India is an energy-deficient country and Russia an energy-surplus one, and records that Russia remains the only foreign military supplier from whom India is able to procure high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere, including nuclear-powered submarines; the owners instruct that complementarity is the correct word for the overall relationship while the narrower installed-base and spares dependence must be named precisely, because energy complementarity and equipment dependence are different claims that carry different risks.

14. **The Russian installed base, joint production and third-party sanctions exposure:** Licensed production of the Su-30MKI and the BrahMos joint venture demonstrate co-production alongside procurement, the S-400 contract of 2018 is the named high-end acquisition, and the AK-203 joint venture through Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa represents an attempt to localise production whose localisation depth, component sourcing and production milestones must be verified separately; the recorded risk is that installed-base and spares concentration creates dependence even where the overall relationship is described as complementary, and that the S-400 purchase created exposure to possible United States sanctions under another state's domestic law, which is exposure and secondary risk rather than an international-law obligation on India.
15. **The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit of December 2025:** The twenty-third India-Russia Annual Summit was held in New Delhi on 4 and 5 December 2025 during President Putin's state visit, producing a joint statement titled Russia-India: A Time-Tested Progressive Partnership, Anchored in Trust and Mutual Respect, with a Programme for Development of Strategic Areas of Economic Cooperation until 2030 among the documents adopted; the owners require that S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes be treated as separately unverified without an official figure, so the summit may be cited as continuity evidence while no delivery or volume number is asserted on its authority.
16. **The India-China border and dialogue architecture as process, not settlement:** On 21 October 2024 the Ministry of External Affairs announced an agreement on patrolling arrangements along the Line of Actual Control leading to disengagement and a resolution of the issues that had arisen in these areas in 2020, later specified as covering Depsang and Demchok, the twenty-third Special Representatives round met in Beijing on 18 December 2024 and the twenty-fourth in New Delhi on 19 August 2025 agreeing an Expert Group on early harvest boundary delimitation, a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination working group on border management and General-Level Mechanisms in the Eastern and Middle sectors and providing for reopening border trade through the existing designated points of Lipulekh, Shipki La and Nathu La, the Prime Minister met President Xi at Tianjin on 31 August 2025, and the thirty-fifth Working Mechanism meeting was held in Beijing on 27 May 2026 to prepare the next Special Representatives meeting; the owners are categorical that this is a patrolling and process architecture and not a boundary settlement.
17. **The United States tariff cycle of 2025-26 as an architecture stress test:** An India-specific reciprocal tariff of twenty-five per cent took effect on 7 August 2025 under Executive Order 14326 and an additional twenty-five per cent Russian-oil-linked duty took effect on 27 August 2025 under Executive Order 14329, the additional duty was removed from 7 February 2026 under Executive Order 14384, the International Emergency Economic Powers Act additional duties including the reciprocal duty were ended by Executive Order 14389 in February 2026, and a separate ten per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods applied from 24 July 2026, while India officially called the Russian-oil-linked action unjustified and unreasonable on 4 and 6 August 2025; the owners record this as the clearest available evidence that friend-shoring partnership and coercive trade measures can run simultaneously from the same partner, and require these measures to be cited as dated, reversible executive actions rather than as a standing rate or settled trade policy.
18. **The Japan pillar as a non-treaty security, infrastructure and technology partner:** The India-Japan relationship was elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership in 2014, the third Foreign and Defence Ministers' two-plus-two meeting met in New Delhi on 20 August 2024 and agreed to revise the 2008 Joint Declaration on Security Cooperation, the Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services was signed in September 2020 and became operational in 2021, the Japan International Cooperation Agency records cumulative commitments exceeding one trillion Japanese yen since 2017 for the Mumbai-Ahmedabad High-Speed Rail alongside Shinkansen technology, training and station-area cooperation, and Australia, India and Japan launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative in April 2021 for diversification, digital tools and buyer-seller matching; the owners attach the limits directly, namely that logistics access is not a collective-defence commitment, that concessional finance and technology choice do not remove construction, localisation or delivery risk, and that a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish relocated production.
19. **The European Union pillar and the not-yet-in-force qualification:** The European Union-India Trade and Technology Council creates a channel for technology, green-transition and standards cooperation and widens India's technology, market and regulatory options beyond United States-China competition, and free trade agreement negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026, but the owners record that legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force; the discipline this imposes is the Master Framework's legal-status gap

in its clearest form, because a concluded negotiation is neither a signed treaty nor an agreement in force, and regulatory differences plus an agreement not yet in force constrain any claim of immediate gains.

20. The Ukraine posture, minilateral balancing and honest question ownership: Russia's full-scale military action against Ukraine began in February 2022 and India has repeatedly called for dialogue and diplomacy, invoked sovereignty and territorial integrity, supplied humanitarian assistance and generally abstained on polarising United Nations resolutions rather than joining either bloc, with disrupted European-Russian trade redirecting discounted Russian supplies toward India in a gain qualified by sanctions exposure, payment and logistics friction and vulnerability to unilateral tariff or secondary-sanctions pressure, while Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets; minilateral balancing through the non-treaty Quad and I2U2 supplies additional non-exclusive diversification channels at the cost of coordination across partners with differing priorities, and on ownership the audited ledgers route four Mains demands to this owner, namely 2019 General Studies Paper II questions 9 and 20, 2021 General Studies Paper II question 10 and 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, together with two objective demands, namely 2019 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 89 on India's nuclear-field cooperation bilateral action plan and 2026 Prelims General Studies Paper I question 78 on India-Germany bilateral visit outcomes, cooperation and Indo-Pacific dialogue, for which no option or answer is recorded or inferred.

India, China, Major Powers and Resilient Supply Chains: CLOSE-OPTION AND STATUS-UPGRADE TRAPS

- Do not read Western supply-chain diversification as India replacing China, because the owners record diversification of dependence and flag the replacement narrative as incorrect at current scale.
- Do not describe India-United States technology cooperation as a formal military alliance, because the initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology is a cooperation initiative and Tharoor's own framing is a tactical partnership.
- Do not treat the ten-year Framework for the United States-India Major Defense Partnership of 31 October 2025 as a mutual-defence treaty, because a framework creates no collective-defence obligation on India.
- Do not present the Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement, the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement or the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement as an alliance or an automatic basing right, because they are enabling agreements.
- Do not state that TRUST replaced or superseded iCET, because the official statement of 13 February 2025 does not say that it terminated the earlier initiative.
- Do not treat trade volume with China as evidence of strategic trust, because Sikri separates high trade volume from enduring mistrust rooted in an unresolved boundary dispute.
- Do not cite Sikri's book-period ranking or his over ten billion dollar deficit figure as a current number, because both are period evidence and a present-day claim requires current official trade data.
- Do not use de-risking and decoupling interchangeably, because de-risking sustains engagement while decoupling implies full disengagement and India's China policy is the former.
- Do not say that the patrolling arrangement announced on 21 October 2024 settled the India-China boundary, because it covers patrolling arrangements leading to disengagement in Depsang and Demchok while the boundary question continues in the Special Representatives channel.
- Do not describe the Expert Group agreed on 19 August 2025 as a delimitation outcome, because it was agreed for early harvest boundary delimitation and remains a process mechanism.
- Do not treat the 2025-26 United States tariff measures as a fixed feature of the relationship, because they were executive-order-based, were varied, and the additional Russian-oil-linked duty was removed from 7 February 2026.
- Do not treat another state's unilateral sanction or tariff exposure as an international-law obligation on India, because exposure and secondary risk are analytically distinct from a binding duty.
- Do not assert an S-400 delivery status or a Russian-crude volume, because the owners record both as separately unverified without an official figure.
- Do not describe the India-Japan Agreement concerning Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services as a collective-defence commitment, because logistics access is not a defence guarantee.

- Do not describe the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative of April 2021 as relocated production, because a dialogue and matching mechanism does not itself establish manufacturing.
- Do not describe the India-European Union free trade agreement as in force, because negotiations concluded on 27 January 2026 while legal review and ratification remained necessary.
- Do not treat critical-mineral and semiconductor cooperation as an Economy-only matter, because their supply-chain-resilience and technology-access dimension is owned here while the trade and production mechanics are owned by Economy.
- Do not silently correct the printed wording of the 2024 General Studies Paper II question 9, because the owners require the supplied paper text to be reproduced as printed with its apparent defects acknowledged.
- Do not invent a treaty or joint-statement wording, a border or diplomatic status, a summit outcome, a trade, tariff or supply-chain figure, an initiative membership, a military or security development, a policy position, a previous-year question, an answer key or a current claim for this topic.

India, China, Major Powers and Resilient Supply Chains: ANSWER-WRITING SPINE

NAME INDIA'S PRECISE INTEREST -> IDENTIFY THE EXTERNAL ACTOR AND ITS OWN INCENTIVE
-> CHOOSE THE LEVEL: BILATERAL, REGIONAL, MINILATERAL, MULTILATERAL OR DIASPORA
-> CITE ONE DATED INSTRUMENT AND STATE ITS EXACT EVIDENTIARY LEVEL
-> SEPARATE ANNOUNCED FROM SIGNED, SIGNED FROM IN FORCE, IN FORCE FROM DELIVERED
-> NAME THE BINDING CONSTRAINT: ASYMMETRY, RIVAL POWER, PARTNER POLITICS OR CAPACITY
-> CLOSE WITH A CALIBRATED WAY FORWARD AND AN EXPLICIT STRATEGIC-AUTONOMY LINK

India, China, Major Powers and Resilient Supply Chains: LIVE-SOURCE AND DATED-CLAIM BOUNDARY

Live official verification was attempted on 2026-09-03 against the Ministry of External Affairs press-release, bilateral-document and country-brief pages and against the Press Information Bureau release index. Each attempt is recorded honestly above: the Ministry pages returned a browser-requirement stub or the Ministry's own error page and the Press Information Bureau index returned HTTP 403, so no new live item was obtained. The package therefore uses only the dated official anchors already carried by the repository owners, each with its actor, exact evidentiary level and date. It invents no treaty or joint-statement wording, no border or diplomatic status, no summit outcome, no trade, tariff, investment or supply-chain figure, no initiative membership or participation category, no military or security development, no declared policy position, no previous-year question, no answer key and no current claim.

COMPLETE TOPIC ASCII MASTER FLOW DIAGRAM

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 1/12: Three structurally different major-power ties

CHINA -> interdependence plus mistrust; largest trade partner in the book-period assessment; unresolved boundary dispute drives the strategic reading
UNITED STATES -> technology-led tactical convergence; enabling agreements and frameworks; high-technology export restrictions persist
RUSSIA -> defence-energy complementarity; energy-deficient meets energy-surplus; high-technology equipment unavailable from elsewhere
RULE -> a three-track hedge, never a binary China-versus-West alignment
MUST REMEMBER: India's relations with China and other major powers combine border...
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ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 2/12: Policy-term discipline

DE-RISKING -> reduce overconcentration while sustaining engagement; India's posture
DECOUPLING -> sever engagement altogether; expressly not India's posture
FRIEND-SHORING -> divert critical supply chains toward trusted partners, not cost alone
REPLACEMENT -> the incorrect reading; the correct one is diversification of dependence

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 3/12: India-United States technology timeline

MAY 2022 -> initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology announced
31 JANUARY 2023 -> inaugural National Security Adviser-level meeting
17 JUNE 2024 -> second National Security Adviser-level review
21 SEPTEMBER 2024 -> clean-energy supply-chain commitments announced
13 FEBRUARY 2025 -> TRUST and COMPACT announced with Mission 500 and trade talks
STATUS -> cooperation initiatives and branding; no documented legal succession

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 4/12: Defence architecture ladder

2016 -> India designated a Major Defence Partner by the United States
LEMOA 2016 -> reciprocal logistics support
COMCASA 2018 -> secure communications
BECA 2020 -> exchange of geospatial information
31 OCTOBER 2025 -> ten-year Framework for the US-India Major Defense Partnership
LIMIT -> enabling agreements and a framework; no collective defence, no basing right

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 5/12: Russia track evidence card

COMPLEMENTARITY -> India energy-deficient, Russia energy-surplus
UNIQUE SUPPLY -> high-technology equipment including nuclear-powered submarines
INSTALLED BASE -> Su-30MKI licensed production; BrahMos joint venture
2018 -> S-400 contract as the named high-end acquisition
AK-203 -> Indo-Russian Rifles Private Limited at Korwa; localisation to be verified
UNVERIFIED -> S-400 delivery status and Russian-crude volumes without an official figure

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 6/12: India-China process architecture

21 OCTOBER 2024 -> patrolling arrangements announced; specified as Depsang and Demchok
-> 18 DECEMBER 2024: twenty-third Special Representatives round, Beijing
-> 19 AUGUST 2025: twenty-fourth round, New Delhi; Expert Group on early harvest delimitation; WMCC working group; General-Level Mechanisms in Eastern and Middle sectors
-> 31 AUGUST 2025: leaders meet at Tianjin
-> 27 MAY 2026: thirty-fifth WMCC, Beijing, prepares the next round
STATUS -> process architecture, expressly not a boundary settlement

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 7/12: Designated border-trade points

LIPULEKH -> existing designated point provided for in the reopening arrangement
SHIPKI LA -> existing designated point provided for in the reopening arrangement
NATHU LA -> existing designated point provided for in the reopening arrangement
SOURCE -> agreed at the twenty-fourth Special Representatives round, 19 August 2025
LIMIT -> provision for reopening trade is not evidence of resumed trade volume

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 8/12: Tariff cycle stress test

7 AUGUST 2025 -> 25 per cent India-specific reciprocal duty, Executive Order 14326
27 AUGUST 2025 -> additional 25 per cent Russian-oil-linked duty, Executive Order 14329
4 AND 6 AUGUST 2025 -> India calls the action unjustified and unreasonable
7 FEBRUARY 2026 -> additional duty removed, Executive Order 14384
FEBRUARY 2026 -> IEEPA additional duties ended by Executive Order 14389
24 JULY 2026 -> separate 10 per cent Section 301 duty on specified Indian goods
READING -> partnership and coercive trade measures ran from the same partner at once

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 9/12: Japan diversification pillar

2014 -> elevated to a Special Strategic and Global Partnership
20 AUGUST 2024 -> third two-plus-two agrees to revise the 2008 security declaration
SEPTEMBER 2020 -> Reciprocal Provision of Supplies and Services signed; operational 2021
SINCE 2017 -> JICA commitments exceeding one trillion yen for high-speed rail
APRIL 2021 -> Supply Chain Resilience Initiative with Australia and Japan
LIMIT -> logistics access is not collective defence; matching is not relocated production

ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 10/12: European Union pillar and legal status

CHANNEL -> Trade and Technology Council for technology, green transition and standards
27 JANUARY 2026 -> free trade agreement negotiations concluded
PENDING -> legal review and ratification remained necessary before entry into force
CONSEQUENCE -> a concluded negotiation is neither signature nor entry into force
GAIN -> wider technology, market and regulatory options beyond US-China competition
CLOSE DISTINCTION: Border claim, Line of Actual Control perception, agreed boundary,...
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ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 11/12: Ukraine engine and minilateral balancing

PRINCIPLES -> dialogue and diplomacy; sovereignty and territorial integrity invoked
-> UN POSTURE: generally abstained on polarising resolutions; humanitarian assistance sent
-> ENERGY AND FERTILISER: discounted supplies redirected toward India
-> EXPOSURE: sanctions risk, payment and logistics friction, unilateral tariff pressure
-> MINILATERAL: non-treaty Quad and I2U2 add channels at a coordination cost
SPILLOVER -> Black Sea disruption affected food, fertiliser, freight and energy markets
EVIDENCE LIMIT: STATUS / LEVELS / IMPLEMENTATION: Distinguish announced initiative,...
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ASCII MASTER FLOW - PANEL 12/12: Answer spine for a major-power demand

OPEN -> state the structural difference between the China, United States and Russia ties
BUILD -> evidence each track with one dated instrument at its exact evidentiary level
TEST -> price the tariff cycle and the technology-access friction as real, dated limits
CLOSE -> refuse the replacement narrative and relink the verdict to strategic autonomy